The Tyrant of Mystacor: Rise of A Queen

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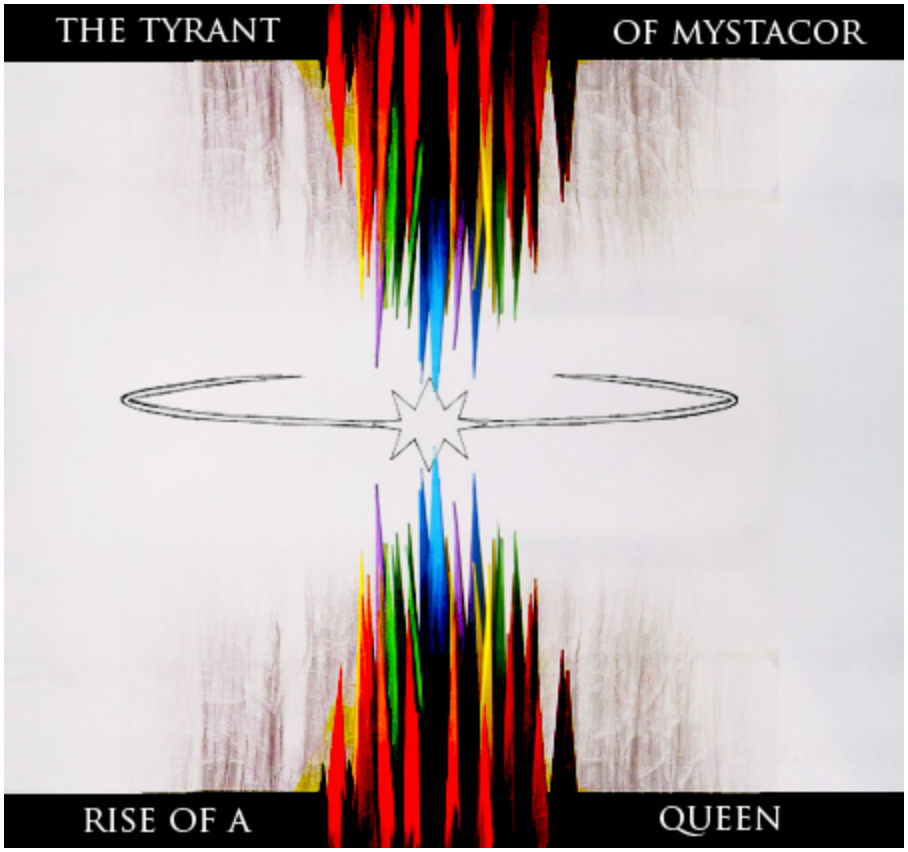
by Xenakis (IceRosesCrown)

Summary

With the dawn of a new era for Mystacor, the kingdom will find itself submerged in serious changes. Just like when the Tyrant first took over, nothing would be the same anymore… But for good, this time…

As Shadow Weaver's key asset grows older, and her position as her right hand is solidified, the new era calls for a new ruler.

A Queen shall rise, and with her, will the progress be boosted or hindered?



Cover by Afteriwake <3

Notes

Bruh, the way I'm running to post this! Everything is ready but I forgot to prepare the chapters to post!!! AAAAAhhhhh

Anyways, here we are! :D

The second part of The Tyrant of Mystacor begins today!! And you can expect the horde kids to show up in the last few chapters (#^_^#)
Also, short apparition of a certain mermaid-like princess woohh!!

And last thing: I'll be posting this every monday and thursday :D

Now yes! Please enjoy!!

Chapter 1

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes



The island of Mystacor, prosperous as it had become, was still home to the most feared individual in Etheria.

More so than Hordak himself.

And yet, Castaspella did not seem to notice.

Or didn't care…

The young sorceress was the kind of person who could only be described as bold, which she proved constantly by defying the Tyrant of Mystacor without hesitation if she considered it necessary.

However, arriving late at a council meeting was… not something she'd normally do.

So, why wasn't she present yet, no one could guess.

But it didn't matter *why*. What mattered was that Shadow Weaver's fury accumulated with each passing second.

Specially since no councillor had managed to get her the *one* thing she requested.

—This is ridiculous— she finally said, standing up. —I will start the meeting without her.

—We-we're sure she will arrive soon— Daryon said, trying to calm her down, to no avail.

—And how could you *possibly* know!?

—She would *never* skip a meeting!— Anya interceded, recoiling as soon as Shadow Weaver looked back at her.

—Enough is enough. You're just hoping she will save you from the punishment you absolutely deserve for your *failure*! But she won't…

—Master, please— Ayax pleaded.

—No— Shadow Weaver insisted. —You must have forgotten what it means to fail when *I* request something— she began, menacingly. —But now, you shall remember…

As Shadow Weaver's magic began to overtake the room, the councillors took deep breaths, embraced for the worst, ready to withstand what they thought *was* a deserved punishment, and closed their eyes.

There was a moment of sheer cold around them.

Everything was silent.

They didn't know what to expect, so they waited, holding their breaths.

But then, the doors slamming open startled them, made them jump in their place and open their eyes again.

—What the heck do you think you're doing!?

—I should be asking you that— the Tyrant retorted, calling back her shadows and letting the Council see it was none other than Castaspella.

She had finally appeared.

—*I* am arriving a bit late to the meeting, isn't that obvious?— the sorceress mocked her, reaching her place at the table and setting down a box she had brought.

—Came to join your fellows? You must have a death-wish since there is *no way* you can save them this time— she scoffed. —It doesn't matter whether you have my favour or not, *you* should be punished too!

—Right— Castaspella uttered, rolling her eyes.

Without another word, she tapped the box and slid it closer to Shadow Weaver.

—What is this?

—Open it and find out— the sorceress dared her, smirking. —Oh, right, and I almost forgot this— she then added, making a huge effort to teleport a large bag to the middle of the table. She took out a small wooden piece from inside, passed it to Daryon next to her so the councillors on her right could inspect it, and then fetched another to let the others on her left

see it too. —I would like you all to wear this, and give them to your squads too. They are protection charms. They have to be recharged after around five hard hits, but I can do that easily. The idea is just to give you enough time to escape if I'm not there to help you.

Impressed, the councillors began questioning her about the charms; how she had done them, where she got the idea, why spend so much time and energy on them…

And while Castaspella explained how she had been making them the past year with the intention to have them ready far earlier, Shadow Weaver inspected the contents of the box in utter silence.

It was… exactly what she had asked for.

Inside the box there had to be about a dozen, perfectly pure and intact lunar crystals infused with the power of the Moons of Enchantment.

The process was complicated, to say the least, and most times the crystals would shatter from the sheer power of the Moons… So how exactly had Castaspella managed what none of her own pupils could? She needed to know *now*.

—Everyone *out*— she suddenly ordered, interrupting the council's questioning without looking up from the box. —Except Castaspella. Everyone else, leave— she then clarified, finally looking at them.

—But…

—Just go— the young sorceress interrupted Anya. —And take the bag with you. I'll be out soon.

—Are you sure?

—Yes. Don't worry, Daryon.

—You heard her, now *out*— Shadow Weaver insisted, closing the box. They silently observed as the councillors poured out of the room and, once the doors closed, Castaspella folded her arms and raised a brow at the Tyrant. —Now, tell me something: How did you do it? None of them could, the process is complicated…

—It took me the whole week to prepare, and I probably broke far more crystals than I could afford, but I had to. I wanted to do it. And I can be just as stubborn as you— she interrupted, a bit smug. —You ask for it, I get it for you. Simple as that.

—Are you looking for greater favour from me, or what?— she began, moving closer to the sorceress.

The old woman slowly took her mask off, revealing a teasing smirk.

—I am just doing my job and what I think is best for Mystacor.

—Oh, of course. You're always so selfless… Won't use your favour to reach for more power but rather to *help the people*.

—Indeed. I'm still offended that you would think I'd be as greedy as you— Castaspella scoffed, looking away.

—I know now, as I am well aware that you're far too gentle for that— Shadow Weaver further teased her, stepping into her personal space and towering over her. —And, much to my surprise, I find that quite enticing from you— she admitted, moving her face closer but stopping before their lips met.

—Is that so?— Castaspella let out, smiling smugly. —Why did you stop, then? Why didn't you kiss me just now?

—If you can figure that out on your own, I'll reward you.

And the young sorceress *had* to take the challenge.

After thinking for a moment, she realized —You're doubting.

—How so?

—You *were* going to kiss me as you did years ago on my birthday— Castaspella explained. —But now that I've gotten bolder, now that you *know* I can't be swayed by the promise of power, you're *hesitant*. You… are afraid.

—Of what?

—Being the one subdued or weakened… instead of me.

Castaspella half-expected her to get angry, or at least to frown.

But she didn't…

On the contrary, Shadow Weaver seemed pleased at how well the young sorceress managed to read her.

Without a word, the Tyrant picked her up and sat her on the table; they finally began kissing, and just as Castaspella wondered what the "reward" could be, she felt it.

However, the rising heat was promptly cut short as they heard the doors about to open.

Just great…

Shadow Weaver quickly moved back and the young sorceress jumped down from the table, brushing down her dress to hide any trace of what was happening a second before.

—Excuse the interruption, Master, but according to the schedule Castaspella put together, we must go for the supplies now before the market closes…— Kenno explained himself, feeling like he *did* walk into something.

—Right! Right… I should… go.

Reluctantly, Shadow Weaver nodded at her to leave, and Castaspella tried not to look too dejected as she followed Kenno out.

Well, it wasn't ideal, but Castaspella had to admit Kenno was right. They would lose an entire day if they didn't go shopping right away.

A real shame, however, since the young sorceress felt pretty… *aroused*.

Ugh…

Time to see how well she can hide it.

Normally, she'd be doing this with Daryon, so she wouldn't have to worry much, but since this time he was busy and instead Kenno filled in for him, Castaspella had to take the lead.

And it was difficult to focus.

—Where do we begin?

—You… do have the list, right?— she asked, concerned.

—Yes, yes… somewhere… here— the sorcerer nodded, checking all the folds of his robes. —Ha! Here!

—Great. Let's follow this list first, and if we recall anything else in the way, we can add it too.

—Alright. Uh…

—What is it?

—Are you okay?

—O-of course?

—You seem a bit uncomfortable. Did something happen?

—Of course not— she quickly dismissed him. —It's nothing.

—Listen, we know Shadow Weaver can be intimidating, but you have *nothing* to fear. I promise.

—I-I know.

—It's clear you've gotten into our Master's good graces, so no matter what she says, you can be *sure* she will never harm you. Or see you harmed, either…

—Really?— she asked, fishing for more.

—Of course! We… have noticed how she subtly defends you, constantly insists you should be respected for your knowledge and invaluable advice, and that we're all safe thanks to you — he explained. —And she's right!

So… that's what he meant.

Curious…

However, he never mentioned the little "test" that the council absolutely knew about…

—I see— she sighed.

—Besides, she usually remarks that you're the only one skilled enough to survive if anything ever happened to Mystacor. You-you can take care of yourself fully, you even make your own clothes! And we suppose that explains why Shadow Weaver always wants everyone to immediately answer her call whenever she needs us, *but not you*.

—Wha- Really?

—Yeah… She always asks if you're available or not, and if you're asleep, or eating, or even just in your free time doing whatever, she dismisses it and says she'll ask you later— Kenno chuckled.

—Oh… I-I had no idea.

—It's alright. It's a good sign.

—And… what if I taught you all how to do those things? Wouldn't it please the Tyrant if she considers that would make you all more competent?— she offered. —I'm not saying you're incompetent, that's bullshit… But she thinks…

—I know— Kenno interrupted, smiling gently. —That's actually a good idea. We should tell the others and organize some… sort of workshop to learn basic skills then— he agreed.

—That would be perfect! Once we're back, let's gather everyone and we can organize a schedule!

Kenno and Castaspella arrived by nightfall, carrying so many supplies that some things almost fell off their bags right as they arrived. A few acolytes quickly appeared to help them, and once they were sure things would be handled, Castaspella and Kenno gathered the rest of the council, as agreed, and the young sorceress explained her proposal.

—So… You'll teach us how to knit and sew?— Ekaterina asked, a bit confused.

—Of course! And anything else you might not know that can be useful— she beamed. — Look, I'll finish this right now to show you how many things can be done with the right

elements and skill— she proposed, producing a baby-pink bundle of fabric. As she unfolded it, she explained —This is my latest work: A cape! It has these golden details and shoulders. As you can see, I used two different fabrics for the inside and the outside, which will make it heavier and more suitable for a cape. I only need to sew the last stretch of the edges and it will be done.

The council watched with fascination as Castaspella demonstrated how to pass the thread through the needle with ease, how to sew with different kinds of stitches depending on what they wanted to do, and how they wanted it to look.

Once her pretty new cape was ready, she put it on and they could see just how well-crafted it was, which got them *really* excited.

None of them had considered they could actually make their own clothing, however they wanted it, and now they *needed* to learn how.

Having such good reception, Castaspella humored them and they remained until well past midnight discussing the projects each wanted to do, and setting up a schedule…

Chapter End Notes

Alright! See you on Thursday!!!

I need to start working, so I'll read you later in the comments, cause I'm sure I'm forgetting to say something here lol

Bye!! Thanks for reading!!

Chapter 2

Chapter Summary

> "You… represent all the things I've abandoned. Everything I have no hope for because of my past, which I can't help but admire…" ~ SW

Chapter Notes

> Ok! Posting at midnight cause I won't have much time tomorrow morning!! Woohoo!! I'll answer comments asap, but for now, just enjoy!! :D
>
> Everyone, please welcome: Castaspella's cape! XD

See the end of the chapter for more notes



Another "fructiferous" meeting of the council had just ended when Castaspella was stopped by Shadow Weaver on her way out of the chamber.

—What is it now?— the young sorceress asked, hands on her hips.

—What are you wearing?— the Tyrant asked back, eying her brand-new cape.

—Do you like it? I made it!— she smiled brightly.

—It's… very pink.

—You don't like it…— Castaspella realized, suddenly full of dread.

—And you care?

—Of course!

—You shouldn't. Don't be stupid. If *you* like it, why should you care whether *I* do?

Shadow Weaver sounded aloof as expected, but it didn't escape the sorceress that she was, weirdly enough, trying to be "supportive".

Odd.

—Thanks for the advice?— Castaspella uttered, confused. —Are you feeling alright?

—Sure…

—Ah… We'll talk more later, alright?— she sighed, itching to hold her hand or *something* but refusing to do so since it would likely anger the woman as they could be seen. —I have work to do…

—As you wish— the Tyrant agreed, sounding quite tired.

It was strange, seeing Shadow Weaver like that, and a feeling of unease followed Castaspella the rest of the day.

However, she made her best effort to stay focused and "give her class" to the her fellow councillors.

It was a slow day, so they had all the time in the world to focus on learning new skills.

They began by practicing a few stitches, learnt some pattern-making, and then moved onto starting each of their personal projects.

Castaspella was sure this would be the best way to learn new skills: Applying them!

By the time she arrived at Shadow Weaver's chamber that night, the young sorceress was feeling quite accomplished.

—Evening!— she announced herself as she walked in.

—You're finally here— the Tyrant noticed. —I was starting to wonder whether you'd show up or not.

—Why wouldn't I come?

—I've learnt of your *selfless* offer to help those pathetic councillors be at least half as capable as you…— she began, smirking. Her mask laid on the desk while her clothes had already been exchanged for her night robes. —It's good to see you weren't too busy to remember your promise to "talk later"— she added, dragging the point. —After all, we have many things to discuss.

—Oh, really? So you want to talk about whatever was going on with you this morning?— Castaspella defiantly asked, folding her arms as she approached.

—Sure, but first: Why don't you tell me about those personal things you've been getting while shopping for the Island's supplies?

—Hold on, hold on. I buy my stuff with my own money!

—*Only* your stuff?— Shadow Weaver insisted, squinting.

—Shit. You are talking about…

—The supplies for Mystacor that you *also* buy with your money, yes— she interrupted, standing up to approach the sorceress too. —You can't keep making up for the missing money. If the funds aren't enough, then you *don't* buy "everything needed", only the essentials.

—But if it's needed…

—No buts. The Island is now indebted to you. Was that your goal?

—No, no!

—Then listen to me, Castaspella, and stop buying supplies for everyone with your personal money— she insisted, stopping in front of her. —Once again, I have to remind you you're only safe because of my favour. Otherwise, I would have to punish you for forcing this situation.

—Then resign the favour if you *so* want to punish me, I don't care. I'll keep helping Mystacor however I can, and there's absolutely no debt as far as I'm concerned.

—Wrong answer.

—Fuck you…

—*Adorable*— the Tyrant mocked her. But only for a moment before she noticed something. Castaspella wasn't looking so defiant anymore. —What's wrong?

—Who else knows?

—About?

—The money I've been putting to buy supplies.

—No one, as far as I know.

—Oh… Good…

—I'll ask again: What's wrong? Why are you suddenly so scared?— she pressed on, suspicious.

—I-I just… It's the same as usual. I don't want people to think I'm somehow "buying" that favour you *so* love to remind me you're giving me…

—I wouldn't let that happen and you *know* that. We don't have to do anything you don't want to— Shadow Weaver reminded her, gently grabbing her chin to make her look at her. —Am I clear?

—O-of course. I don't… Ah…— Castaspella sighed. —It's not that I don't want to. I just- I don't like how it feels… doing it all *hidden*. Besides, it's obvious to *everyone* that you're favouring me and, to be honest, even I myself don't know why you do!

—That's easy to fix— she smirked. —In short, you've proved me wrong time and again. When I first met you, I only paid attention to you because you were Micah's sister. I *know* I said otherwise, but that's the truth. And yet, only a few weeks later, you proved to me you were *more* than just his sister. Every presumption I'd made, you demonstrated that you're even better than I could imagine, that your intentions are pure, perhaps too much for my taste, and that you care for others to an extent I do not. You're willing to give your all for others…— she explained. —You… represent all the things I've abandoned. Everything I have no hope for because of my past, which I can't help but admire…— she admitted. Then, with a deep breath, the Tyrant finally proposed —If you prefer, then I'd have no problem making it all public. If we make it official, I suppose it'll stop looking so suspicious. And, of course, I wouldn't let anyone disrespect you.

—You *mean it*?— the young sorceress asked, eyes shining.

Before replying, Shadow Weaver smirked and pulled her in for a kiss.

—Of course. I want *everyone* to know you're mine; the brightest mind of Mystacor, to whom almost everyone owes their lives, belongs to me— she said, in a low tone. —Or, not "belong", if you prefer, just… "favours me as much as I do". What do you think?

Castaspella couldn't help but smile wide and nodded, throwing her arms around the Tyrant's neck.

Shadow Weaver picked her up, took her to the bed, and laid down with her while they kissed for a moment.

—I would love that— the young sorceress finally said.

—Then you'll have to let me mark you.

—Okay?— Castaspella giggled, raising a brow, unsure of what that meant.

With a mischievous smirk, the old woman caught her in another kiss.

Hotter, this time.

Literally burning.

What was happening!?

She'd soon find out…

Humming in pain as the burning sensation became unbearable, Castaspella closed her eyes tightly, hoping it'd end soon, not daring to push her away.

For some reason, she didn't *want to* push her away.

Fortunately it did end soon.

As Shadow Weaver pulled away, the cool air got rid of the burning sensation pretty quickly and the young sorceress could open her eyes again.

The Tyrant was looking at her with a glint of something…

Suspicious.

—Black suits you— she then whispered, smirking still.

—Huh?

She was looking at her lips.

What exactly did she mean!?

—You may want to check the mirror.

—What did you do… Oh, my Stars… Will I regret accepting?

—I sure hope you won't.

Huffing, Castaspella got up from the bed and went to Shadow Weaver's vanity.

And sure enough, there it was: "black lipstick" on her lips.

—This is *not* lipstick— she told herself.

—No.

—What is this?

—Just the mark I mentioned.

—What does it do?

—It's symbolic.

—Woman…

—I'm telling you it's symbolic. It's just that. Won't affect you in any way but sends a clear message— she explained, still laying in bed comfortably.

—I don't… hate it? But it's so *strange*— Castaspella admitted, looking at her reflection with more detail. —I don't even use make-up, this is so weird…

—I still think it suits you.

—Thank you— she said this time, blushing. —But… What will I say when asked about it?

—You *can* lie and say it's mere lipstick… Or you can answer it's none of their business. It'll be evident to everyone once we make it public.

—So we're actually announcing it like some kind of event?

Shadow Weaver cackled and stood up from the bed to approach her.

—You want it to be an event? I can do that…

—I don't know? I'm not sure…

—We'll do whatever you prefer.

—I suppose a public announcement *would* make things easier for me— Castaspella admitted, sighing. —Alright. Let's do that, then. I have no idea what could be said, but as long as you make sure I don't look like some…

—You won't look like anything you aren't. My partner; that's what you are.

The sorceress let out a soft smile that the Tyrant couldn't resist and they kissed again, more tenderly this time.

Several hours later, they were lying in bed on each other's arms, breath shallow as they recovered from an exhausting make-out session.

Castaspella buried her face on Shadow Weaver's neck and hummed, satisfied. Slowly, she began kissing the Tyrant under her chin, pressing her lips deliberately over the tender skin of her scars.

Eventually, she surrendered to sleep with just one thought in her mind: the following day would change everything. Hopefully for the best…

She'd make sure of that.

Chapter End Notes

And that was all for this week!!

See you soon on Monday!!

Chapter 3

Chapter Summary

When she first stepped outside and saw the flying ships, Castaspella lost her breath.

She almost lost all hope.

They had been *found*. The Horde had *reached them*.

They could *fly*!

Everything that put them at an advantageous position, vanished in a second.

Chapter Notes

Man, midnight took so LONG to come, omgs…

Anyways, welcome to a new chapter!!!!!
I'm excited about this one, but there are better chapters still XD

Ahem, regardless! I hope you enjoy!!

See the end of the chapter for more notes



The following morning, Castaspella woke up early, took a bath, got ready to pick up some breakfast from the kitchen, and told Shadow Weaver she'd see her later to organize the announcement.

On the other hand, the Tyrant didn't get up until noon, hardly recalled having spoken to the young sorceress, and when they met for lunch, she was shocked for a second seeing her black lips.

Right.

She had marked her.

She forgot about that, as a matter of fact.

However, she perfectly disguised her surprise.

—Afternoon…— she greeted her.

—Good afternoon!— Castaspella replied, cheerful as ever. —So? What are we going to do for the "announcement"?

—Hmm… What, indeed. Something dramatic, maybe— the old sorceress smirked.

—Why?

—Why not?— she insisted, her grin widening mischievously.

—Be-because… I-I don't want to cause a scene…

—This *will* cause a scene, like it or not.

—Why!?

—Because *me* having a partner is unthinkable for the Council and the people of Mystacor. I am supposed to be the heartless tyrant, remember?— Shadow Weaver explained.

—That's ridiculous, you're not… I mean, um…

—See? The "ridiculous" idea is me *having* a partner, or rather, loving someone and being loved in return.

—But- I-I mean… the Council… They all love you— Castaspella pointed out. —Like, yeah, I guess the idea of *you* loving someone is still wild, but… There has to be a way of going public without causing an uproar!

—Why are you so concerned about their reactions?

—Why *aren't* you!?

—Why should I be? When have I cared about anyone's reactions?

—That's not exactly a positive trait, you know?— Castaspella grunted. —If you don't care about what people think at least a bit, then they won't care about you either. They won't respect you.

—Well, you care too much and that doesn't help you either.

—Okay, okay, so… I care too much, you care too little. We should balance each other out!— the young sorceress proposed. —Let's plan this each our way and then we'll compare how we'd do it. I'll take advice from you and you can take some from me…

—I must ask, once again, why you'd let me rule and not take the lead yourself— Shadow Weaver interrupted. —You're much better suited for this than me.

—N-no, no. I- No. I'm better where I am, trust me. Some decisions… I simply can't make them. I… don't have your resolve.

—I see— the Tyrant hummed. —Then let's do as you say. But, this announcement won't just make you officially my partner…

—What else would it make me?

—A co-leader of sorts— she smirked. —You don't want to take the lead? Alright. No problem. But you've been helping me lead all this time, and now I want that to be acknowledged.

—I'm already part of the council, I'm not…

—But you're far superior than them— Shadow Weaver scoffed. —Keeping you at their level is stupid, besides the fact that, being the youngest member, you are seen as lesser…

—I'm seen as- Right, of course— Castaspella realized, mid-sentence, replacing her indignation with resignation.

—Good to know you understand— the old woman condescendingly said. —Well, then, time to start planning, taking *that* into account.

—Alright… Oh, about our lunch: It may be a bit hot yet— she smiled, opening her bento box.

—Don't tell me you cooked it yourself again…

—Of course!

—Why?

—I like cooking for you?

—Right…

—Fine. I was a bit stressed and wanted to cook something, alright?

—I knew it— she smirked. —I should ask now: Would you like to be… De-stressed?

Her look said enough.

—Perhaps… But, after eating— she smiled.

—Deal.

They had barely finished eating and were starting their usual flirting and teasing game, when an explosion rang through Mystacor and a magical alarm began blaring.

—What the heck was that!?— Castaspella reacted, looking at the covered window and considering taking a look outside.

—Nothing good— Shadow Weaver replied. —Follow me— she ordered, striding out of the room. Feeling her footsteps rush behind her, she went on —I can almost assure you we're under attack.

—How are you so sure?

—The island wouldn't spontaneously shake, you know? And that sounded like bombs or explosions… The Horde must be behind this— she replied.

—What do we do?

—*You* will do what you do best: defend and protect us. I'll handle the rest— she smirked, briefly looking back.

—Wa-wait, are you sure!?

—I trust you. Do you?

—Trust *you*? Yes. Trust myself!? No idea…

—Listen…— she insisted, raising her voice over the loud alarm and accelerating the pace as they heard another explosion. —You go to the entrance and check the state of things. I'll handle the people and then find you. Just buy yourself enough time until I join you.

—But…

—*And*, this will be even better of an announcement. Wouldn't you say?

—I…

—Casta— she stopped her for a moment. —I know you can do this. Don't make me look like the hopeful one— she told her, grabbing her chin. —I'll join you soon, and *we* will show the Horde that Mystacor is not to be messed with.

Castaspella let out a sigh and tiptoed to kiss her for a moment before giving the Tyrant a resolute nod.

Each went their separate ways then; the young sorceress rushed down the stairs while Shadow Weaver remained upstairs to find the councillors and start giving instructions.

When she first stepped outside and saw the flying ships, Castaspella lost her breath.

She almost lost all hope.

They had been *found*. The Horde had *reached them*.

They could *fly*!

Everything that put them at an advantageous position, vanished in a second.

What was she supposed to do!?

Oh, anything but give up. That's for sure.

She kept running, closer to the entrance of Mystacor, and saw the biggest ship preparing a cannon or something, charging to fire.

The previous hits had apparently landed on empty ground, on the soil *under* Mystacor, probably with the intention of making the land collapse. She wasn't sure.

But this time? This looked like it would hit directly the buildings.

And she couldn't allow it.

Yelling at the top of her lungs, Castaspella made an effort to cast the largest possible shield she could achieve.

She was forfeiting resilience in exchange for size, but she knew that if she could, at least, resist one shot, she'd gain some time while they charged again…

She had to trust it'd be enough to resist until Shadow Weaver showed up as promised.

Shadow Weaver could see the large shield extending between the Horde ships and the buildings and immediately knew what Castaspella planned.

—That idiot— she muttered. Looking back at the councillors, she barked —You all have your orders, now move!

—Yes, Master!— they all replied, before sprinting their separate ways, ready to follow her instructions, keep the people safe and out of danger.

—Casta…— she sighed, considering straight up jumping down the window. But maybe it was better to just teleport down… —Casta!— she called, appearing close to her. But the sorceress ignored her. —The bigger you make it, the weaker it will be!— she warned her.

—I know!

—Then let me help— she requested, reaching her side. —Do you trust me?

—How?

—The magical energy sharing techniques you've been teaching…

—No… I- Your magic…

—It won't taint you, I promise.

—But…

—If you don't accept the power I share, that blast may kill us all— she insisted. —So, I'll say it only once: *please*, trust me.

—I…— she hesitated. They were running out of time, she had to make a choice. And everyone was looking. Everyone depended on them. Shadow Weaver made a choice and hoped, maybe, Castaspella would follow suit. She kissed her for a second and offered her power to her. —I trust you— Castaspella finally sighed, with tears in her eyes.

With the whole island watching, the sorceresses let their magical energies combine to empower the risen shield, and it gradually turned from light-blue to dark purple… the mere sorcery combined with the power of black magic.

And right as the shield turned fully dark, the mighty blast hit.

But it *wasn't* enough.

Their defenses prevailed.

Shadow Weaver remained behind Castaspella, holding her and reminding her to let the power just flow from her to the spell.

—Don't fight it, don't fear it…

But she didn't fear it.

She trusted her.

And so the shield held.

Even when the Horde ships crashed against it, the spell didn't break…

Castaspella began sweating, gasping for air as she felt her strength wearing thin, but the Tyrant didn't move an inch, kept her standing, secured her.

As the first few ships exploded against the shield yet caused no harm, the remaining ones retreated.

The young sorceress could drop the shield.

Yet as soon as she did, she almost fainted.

—They… are gone— she sighed.

—They are. And I've got you— Shadow Weaver assured her.

—Thank you…

—Shush now. You must rest— the old woman insisted, picking her up like she weighted nothing. —I'll take you back inside and you'll rest.

Without another word, Castaspella posed no resistance and was carried inside. Shadow Weaver didn't even have to ask for a chair or a healer. Both were waiting for them when she stepped into the main building.

Hardly conscious, she let the Tyrant feed her a concoction the healer had prepared, and gave the order to call Micah.

—Excuse me, Shadow Weaver— an acolyte replied. —The King is already here.

—Oh shit. That's not good.

—We can hardly hold him back any longer.

—Alright. I'll handle it.

Chapter End Notes

Aaaaaaaaaaand that was all for today!! See you on Thursday!! :D

The best is yet to come (>v<)

Chapter 4

Chapter Summary

> "People don't look scared. The Council is working better. Casta has grown, and that Tyrant is… more reliable." ~ Angella

Chapter Notes

> Oh, this chapter is :3 goods… ksjsjs
>
> Ahem, what I mean is: I consider this chapter kinda important, tho the next one is the real turning point. BUT like, it starts here.
>
> Anyways, I won't spoil anything, just :D Enjoy!!
>
> (I may have forgotten i could post this at midnight lol)

See the end of the chapter for more notes



It was around noon when the first of the Princesses' messengers appeared in Bright Moon.

Angella was barely hearing them out when a second and a third one appeared.

All the Princesses requested the same: that they check what on Etheria was happening in Mystacor.

Well… What was happening?

—I suppose this means we should go personally, no?— Micah considered.

—You go and I'll stay with Glimmer…

—But…

—Oh, right, if the Princesses learn I didn't go, they'll think I didn't take them seriously— she immediately considered, before he could say it himself. —I guess, as she's already asleep, we both can go.

—Good— he smiled.

—You're also worried it may mean trouble for Casta, right?

—Yeah…— he admitted. —Specially if it's something related to Shadow Weaver.

—It may be related to the Horde.

—Worse then.

—Oh, so there *is* something worse than Shadow Weaver for you?— Angella laughed.

—O-of course!

—I'm messing with you, my Love. Let's go.

The regents teleported directly to the island, appeared inside the main hall, and were surprised by a multitude of acolytes.

—Please, remain calm— a councillor was ordering. —Everyone with children under their care, make sure to keep an eye on them.

—Is everyone accounted for?— another councillor asked, surveying the multitude. —Alright, please, stay in this room. If anyone's missing, we'll get them for you.

—What's going on!?— Angella asked, shocked.

—Your Majesties— Anya immediately approached. —Excuse us, we're having a bit of a crisis— she apologetically explained. —Please, come this way.

—Wait- What do you mean "a crisis"!? Where's my sister!?

—I understand your concern, your Majesty, but you must come with me. It'll be simpler that way.

—Let's go, Love— Angella encouraged him, and they both followed Anya to a chamber with windows to the outside.

And so they saw it.

The most dreadful scene they could have found.

Horde ships flying around Mystacor.

A huge vessel with a canon at the front, loading what looked like a deadly laser.

—No…— he exhaled. —Is that… her?

Micah noticed the tiny figure of his sister casting a massive shield, and wondered why it looked like black magic.

Only then did he pay better attention.

—They are…

—Shadow Weaver is helping her cast? How!?— he exclaimed in disbelief.

—We-well, Castaspella has been training different teams on magical energy sharing. This-this must be the same— the councilwoman nervously explained.

—But Shadow Weaver's magic is *malignant*. It could- I-it could hurt Casta!

—Our Master would never allow it— Anya assured him.

Could he trust that?

Well, Micah had no choice.

Angella held him with both hands as comfortingly as possibly as they watched the Horde ships attacking.

When the first ship charged at the shield, she enveloped him with her wings but let him see what happened.

She felt him flinch when the ship exploded… and relax when he noticed the shield stood there still.

—They… are fine?

—Please, wait here. I'll ask someone to let Shadow Weaver know you're here— Anya requested, before leaving the room.

They kept watching until the remaining Horde ships retreated since their attempts at crushing the shield failed, and only after they were out of sight did the shield finally fall.

And Micah couldn't help gasping when he saw Castaspella fall and Shadow Weaver carrying her in her arms.

—I need to see her…

—Wait here, Love. They will come soon, I'm sure.

—But…

—If Casta fainted, all the more reasons to wait until she's in a better condition, don't you think?

—Why am I being kept *here* instead of allowed to *go to her*!?

—Please calm down— Angella begged.

—How!? No- I-I want to see her!— he yelled, knocking on the closed doors with both fists.

—Micah. My Love. Please— the Queen insisted, holding him by the wrists and pulling him into an embrace. —Please, breathe with me, and wait.

—I want to see my sister…

—And you will.

Fortunately, Shadow Weaver went to speak to them as soon as she was notified of their presence.

Micah didn't say a word, didn't look at her.

She knew he blamed her.

—She is *fine*. I am sure she will be able to see you in just a few minutes when she recovers her strength.

—Are you sure?— Angella insisted.

—Of course. A healer is taking care of her at the moment. And I'm sure you'll understand that I would rather return to her now.

—Alright— the Queen accepted. She glanced briefly at Micah and added —Please bring her as soon as she agrees to.

—Of course, your Majesty— Shadow Weaver nodded, bowing briefly but with a slight hint of mockery.

Then she left, closed the door, and a tense silence settled.

They waited… Probably no more than ten minutes, but for Micah it was an eternity.

And finally, Castaspella walked into the chamber.

—Micah?— she asked, before being almost rammed by her brother rushing to hug her. —Oh… Hey, I'm alright!

—I was so worried— he sobbed, holding her tighter.

—Are you sure you're alright?— Angella gently asked, stepping closer.

—Absolutely— she smiled.

As Micah finally released her, he couldn't help noticing and asking —Are you wearing… lipstick?

—Uh…— she hesitated for a second, looking back at Shadow Weaver, who casually stood on the door, laying against the frame. —No?

The Tyrant didn't want to interfere but she refused to leave, so she didn't move an inch or made any gestures.

—What do you mean?— Angella decided to ask, confused.

—Ah… Alright. I- Well, it's not lipstick, it's a mark…

—Mark?

—I'm too tired now, but the short version is… I'm Shadow Weaver's partner.

—*What*!?— Micah reacted, his eye twitching.

—Wait, hold on, Love— his wife stopped him. —Casta, you clearly need to rest. Why don't you go to Bright Moon with us, recover… and then you can explain better?

—I… don't know…— Castaspella muttered, once again looking back at the Tyrant.

—Go— the old woman immediately told her.

—What?

Shadow Weaver realized the sorceress simply didn't want to leave her, and she didn't want her out of her sight either. But, that way, she wouldn't rest at all.

Approaching, she swallowed her pride and let herself be gentle as she insisted —Go with them. Rest, recover. I'll handle this mess and you can return when you feel better.

Castaspella's cheeks went red.

That was unexpected.

—Tha-thank you— she stammered. And before she could regret it, but at the same time wanting to make a point, the young sorceress kissed Shadow Weaver's mask. —I'll go, then.

Soon after Castaspella left with the regents of Bright Moon, Shadow Weaver was informed the Council waited for her at the Council room.

What on Etheria did those fools want now?

Well, she had to attend the meeting in any case, so she saw no reason to delay.

—Alright, everyone— she began, making her way to her place among the shadows. —Are the people safe? Is there any trouble? Do we have casualties?

—No, Master— Daryon denied. —Everyone is safe.

—Then why have I been called here?

—We have a question— Ekaterina chimed in.

—A question? I see… Go ahead. Ask away. I'm sure I'll be *shocked*…

She knew perfectly well what they would ask.

—Have you done anything to Castaspella?

Or not?

What!?

—What do you mean "anything"?

—Have you hurt her in any way?— Daryon clarified.

—No.

—Have you threatened her?

—Plenty, but you know that. She's never yielded.

—Then what exactly happened?— Ekaterina scoffed. —If you've managed to force her into doing anything, I can promise…

—What she means to say…— Ayax interrupted. —Is that we are worried about our fellow councillor. Master, can you promise us you have not broken Castaspella's will?— they asked, noticeably calmer than everyone else.

—Castaspella's will is far stronger than any of us can imagine. I have *not* broken it, nor do I think I can.

—So it's… true. You're together… as a couple— Anya realized.

—Correct— she admitted, nonchalant. —Does that upset you?

—N-no!— Anya quickly denied.

—If that's the case, then we're more than glad— Daryon smiled. —Aren't we?

—We're overjoyed, Master— Kenno began. —For both of you— he smiled. —We feared for her, and for you, because we know this has never been an easy matter for you.

Shadow Weaver chuckled a bit sardonically.

—Is that so? Don't you envy Castaspella now? Don't you resent her?

—Not at all. On the contrary, we treasure her— Kenno said.

—But if you hurt her…— Ekaterina tried to threaten her again, only to be stopped by Daryon.

—I am sure she understands we value Castaspella, Rina. No need to get feisty— he joked.

—Interesting— Shadow Weaver hummed. —Very interesting.

—You can trust us, Master— Ayax began. —We will protect Castaspella. From everything. Even from you.

—What happened in the forbidden corridor will *never* repeat— Daryon promised.

—You better make sure no harm comes to her ever again— the Tyrant warned them, squinting. —And just as you said, even from *me*…

Meanwhile, in Bright Moon, Castaspella was offered a room to rest as much as she needed, and passed out almost immediately.

She was *drained*.

Her dreams, unfortunately, didn't let her rest much.

Visions filled with shadows, darkness, and ominous images plagued her; the feeling of drowning and falling to the bottom of some thick liquid kept waking her up abruptly.

Her chest hurt from the anguish of those nightmares.

And the last time she woke up, she heard her brother speaking behind the door.

—Come on! I want to see how she's doing!

—She's sleeping! Let her rest!

—But, Angie!

—No buts! You will pester her about Shadow Weaver!

—But…

—What did I just say?

—Aw, come on!

—Micah, you're behaving like a child.

—I'm just worried!

—I know! But you must let her *rest*.

—She's been resting since we returned!

—Micah, my Love, please…

—I-I'm just…

—I know.

—Angie. Do you think she did anything to her?

—If I'm honest, no. I don't think Shadow Weaver did anything to Casta… More like it's the other way around.

—What do you mean?— Micah asked, confused.

Surprised and intrigued, the young sorceress stood up from the bed and approached the door to listen more clearly.

—You know Shadow Weaver better than me. You should have noticed— Angella began. —That woman has changed. Maybe not too much, but enough that it's noticeable. And for the best! Casta said Mystacor is getting better, and she's right. I can see that.

—I-I mean…

—People don't look scared. The Council is working better. Casta has grown, and that Tyrant is… more reliable.

—You think?

—I know it. I've seen and heard enough.

—But…

—My Love— Angella interrupted. —Please promise me one thing— she requested.

—Anything.

—Don't judge Castaspella.

Silence.

Her heart skipped a beat with anticipation.

Until, finally, he sighed —I won't.

Chapter End Notes

Hehe :D
So there you have it!

I know, the Council is weird af, yeah…
It's all important tho, I promise >v<

As for Micah's reaction, you'll know next week!!

Wooh!! See you on Monday!! :D

Chapter 5

Chapter Summary

> If awkwardness could end the war, this dinner would have brought peace to Etheria already.

Chapter Notes

> This has to be one of my favourite chapters, guys… I really really hope you enjoy it :D

See the end of the chapter for more notes



Castaspella eventually decided to take a leap in the dark and trust her brother.

And he, as promised, didn't judge her.

However, for the sorceress, his reaction… it was more ominous than anything else.

After explaining how she had been having a secret relationship with the Tyrant, first strictly sexual, and eventually romantic too, he… approached and hugged her in silence.

Then he left…

Angella had no idea what to say, and Castaspella didn't force her to speak either. She gave the Queen a look, like telling her to follow Micah, and then stepped into a balcony.

The sorceress took a deep breath, leant against the balustrade, and slowly sighed.

Night was falling…

Maybe she should return. She felt rested and probably things were calmer in Mystacor.

Besides, she could imagine Shadow Weaver would be restless until she returned, and she herself missed the grumpy woman too…

—Casta…— the sorceress heard behind her, so unexpectedly she jumped slightly, startled.

—Oh my Stars, my Love— she sighed, rushing to hug her.

—Missed me?

—Bitch— she muttered. —Of course— she admitted, burying her face on Shadow Weaver's shoulder.

—So I expected— the old woman smirked, holding her. —But, now that you said it again, I'll have to ask you not to call me that when we're in public.

—Oh- Uh, right. Sorry. What should I call you?

—What do you *want* to call me?

—Something short? I mean, I… Your full name sounds so formal, I feel like I'm chastising you— she laughed.

—You usually are…

—I wonder *why*!

—In any case… Choose anything that isn't too cheesy and we'll be fine.

—I suppose… There's no short form of your name that sounds alright. I can only think of short versions of Light Spinner, but…

—No, not that.

—Something told me you wouldn't like that.

—Indeed. I would rather forget that version of myself.

—Why?

—It's part of the past. Shed skin.

—I understand.

—Good.

—Then…

—I suppose you could… be allowed to use my *real* name— she considered.

—Real? As in…

—Beatrix. Maybe not "real", just, my original name. All my names are or were real, I suppose…

—I see— Castaspella smiled, holding back a giggle. —I can work with that. "Beatrix" sounds beautiful and… "Bea" is actually quite sweet.

—Perhaps too sweet. Keep that one private too.

—Alright— she laughed, rolling her eyes. —Thank you— she then sighed, hugging her again.

—Nothing to thank me for… I shouldn't be here.

—Oh, shit! No, you shouldn't! You- A-as per the agreement with the Princess Alliance, you shouldn't show up uninvited at any kingdom! I can't believe I- Leave before Angella returns!

—Calm down… I just wanted to make sure you were alright. I'll leave now…

—No need— a voice interrupted, startling them both.

—A-Angella. Uh, it's not…

—Easy, Casta, I know— the Queen laughed. —I'm not here to- Ah…— she sighed. After clearing her throat, she started again —I hereby officially invite you, Shadow Weaver, to stay in Bright Moon for… dinner.

Surprisingly enough, she stayed.

But the dinner was… far from ideal.

If awkwardness could end the war, this dinner would have brought peace to Etheria already.

Everything was *so* uncomfortable…

Castaspella felt like a child, in a way, and kept drinking glass after glass of sake.

Micah was silently eating multiple portions of food, pretending he wasn't there.

Angella was *trying* to make conversation with Shadow Weaver.

While the Tyrant… behaved like a Queen.

Utterly shameless, even without her mask.

Nothing unexpected from her, but…

It didn't help.

However, the old woman *was* paying attention to Castaspella across the table, and she did *not* like how much the young sorceress was drinking.

—Casta— she eventually called, completely ignoring Angella. —I think you've had enough sake for the night.

—Shut up…

—I'm not playing games— she insisted. —What's the problem?

—Nothing.

But there *certainly* had to be some problem.

Her behaviour was so strange…

Shadow Weaver thought Castaspella would try to make them all get along or whatever. Yet instead… only Angella tried to make this dinner work.

As she saw her pour herself a new glass of sake, the Tyrant called again —*Casta*.

—*What*!?— she snapped back, after knocking back the aforementioned glass. —Never mind… Save it— she uttered, standing up and stalking away before anyone could say anything else.

Micah finally looked up in time to see her walk out into the nearest balcony, and immediately looked back at Shadow Weaver, frowning.

—Don't you dare blame me now.

—I was just going to ask if you happen to know why she's in such a bad mood all of a sudden.

—I don't know. Maybe because she downed half the bottle of sake on her own?— the Tyrant mockingly retorted. —I wonder why she's drinking so much…

—You tell me!— he scoffed, indignant.

—I wasn't with her all afternoon…

—Alright, enough— Angella interrupted. —This is likely my fault, so… if you could maybe speak with her…

—I'll try— Shadow Weaver sighed, standing up and picking up her mask. —If you'll excuse me…

A very dizzy Castaspella leant against the balustrade just like earlier, when the old woman showed up. This time, however, she didn't call her name, only approached her in silence and held her from behind without putting her mask back on.

—What are you… doing here?— the sorceress asked, slurring the words.

—Making sure you won't jump— Shadow Weaver joked. However, as the joke didn't land, she added —I want to know what upset you so much.

—Nothing…

—It's clearly something.

—Forget it.

—Casta…

—I had… a long day— she groaned. —And it was not… like I hoped.

—I am so very sorry, but I need you to tell me what you mean exactly.

—Be-Bea… I was- I told them everything… and Micah- He just… hugged me in silence. Like- It was like… I don't know… felt like he was mourning.

—I don't think he was…

—You weren't there— Castaspella cut her. —A-and now… and now Angella kept asking about Mystacor, and the people, and the council, and… ugh…

—What's wrong with that?

—She's… she's…

—What? What is she doing?

—She's judging everything! Just because her kingdom is so prim and proper… Some Queen Perfection she is— Castaspella complained, dragging the words even more.

Shadow Weaver wanted to cackle but had to hold back, knowing the regents were probably eavesdropping.

—That's the alcohol speaking— she said, loud enough to be heard. Then, holding her closer, she muttered —But I can tell you she's far from perfect.

—What do you know?

—She tries too hard— Shadow Weaver assured her, still whispering. She then gave her an intense kiss on the neck, under her ear, humming lowly. —And she's not half as sensual as you while at it— she added, laughing under her breath.

—Shut up…— the young sorceress giggled, leaning back against the Tyrant. —I'm sorry…

—Don't apologize.

—I ruined the dinner…

—Not your fault you felt so nervous you drank half the bottle of sake— Shadow Weaver insisted. —Now: why don't you go back inside, have some water, and talk to your brother?— she suggested, letting go of Castaspella and looking back over her shoulder to find the regents lingering at the entrance.

—Fine…— the sorceress complied. —Can we go back afterwards?

—Of course— she nodded, kissing her forehead before letting her go.

Then, she put her mask back on and observed as Castaspella approached Micah, and both carefully returned inside. As soon as they were away, Shadow Weaver gave the Queen a stern look.

—What?

—Eavesdropping isn't proper for someone of your position— the Tyrant reproached her.

Angella frowned, offended, and folded her arms.

—If you need to talk…

—I do, indeed— she admitted, turning around to overlook Bright Moon.

—About Casta, I presume.

—Correct.

—What is the problem? I swear I don't care about her drunken speech, really— Angella promised, standing next to her at a prudent distance.

—It's not about that. And you better pretend she didn't say anything. I *will* call you crazy if you ever bring it up— Shadow Weaver threatened.

—Alright! Sure! Now, *what* do you want to discuss?

—In relation to her drunken speech, I mostly wanted to know if she has always had this… self-esteem issue.

—Oh, well… Yes, I suppose. From what I know, she always compared herself to Micah, and… to me since we met. Her capabilities are the basis of her self-esteem…

—And what do you think about her, your Majesty?

—I think… I've always thought, and still think, that she's… actually stronger than either of us.

—Elaborate.

—I mean… Casta wasn't born powerful like me, and she doesn't have a gift like Micah. She… she made herself as powerful as needed. She- What she did today, what she's been doing for the people of Mystacor… it was no blessing from a higher power, no talent, no piece of cake. It took all her effort, and even more.

—And she didn't cheat her way into power either— Shadow Weaver added, smirking under the mask. —She's stronger than me too…

—Of course— Angella nodded. —If she had an ounce of our advantages, she'd rule the whole world— the Queen laughed.

—She would— the Tyrant added. —And everyone would thank her…

—Absolutely.

The women fell silent for a moment.

The chilly breeze of the night whistled in their ears.

After a few minutes, Angella blurted out —I apologize.

—For?

—Making Casta feel judged. I was genuinely curious about Mystacor.

—Forget it, your Majesty— Shadow Weaver dismissed her. —Do me a favour and pretend that dinner never happened— she insisted. She then turned, aiming to leave, but stopped herself as she remembered —Actually, I intended to make a formal request to you tonight.

—What would that be?

—I want to ask you, as the Queen of the Princess Alliance, to recognize Castaspella as the *Queen of Mystacor*.

—What?— Angella uttered, confused. —Could you clarify what you mean? Are you resigning your title?

—No, not at all— Shadow Weaver denied. —I will remain the Tyrant of Mystacor as it was stipulated in our agreement, *but* now that Casta is officially my partner, I do *not* want her to be called my "consort" or anything worse— she explained, stern. —I am asking for her authority to be recognized in order for her to get the respect she deserves— she further clarified.

The rise in her pitch was enough for Angella to understand Shadow Weaver wasn't joking. Perhaps she was being quite condescending, but that tone implied a bit of an underlying threat.

—I'll make that happen— Angella accepted. —I don't even need to consider it, I am glad you asked— she admitted. —My relationship with Castaspella is a bit awkward at times, probably would be much more strained without Micah, but… I care about her, and you just dispelled the last of my doubts about her relationship with you— the Queen disclosed.

—Good— she smirked.

Now Shadow Weaver could leave in peace.

—Oh, before you go…— Angella stopped her. —Remember the actual crown of Mystacor you rejected? I believe the crafter still lives in Mystacor— she reminded her. —May be worth a visit, wouldn't you say, Tyrant?

—You're right, your Majesty— she smirked. —Good evening.

Chapter End Notes

Hah! Yes! It means *exactly* what you think!!

Casta's getting the crown!! >v<
At long last!!

Ahem… but anyways, this isn't even half-way there, since I have ten more chapters to post lol
So, uh, see you this Thursday with ch 6!! :D

Thanks for reading!!!

Chapter 6

Chapter Summary

> "I would rather you learnt to apologize *at the right moment and time*, to whom it *corresponds*" ~ Castaspella

Chapter Notes

> Oops! I apologize! I couldn't wait till midnight yesterday <("^_^) Today's my last day at the office, and I needed to wake up early...
>
> ANYWAYS, please enjoy today's chapter!
> Special guest: Mermista and her father! XD

See the end of the chapter for more notes



It was a rainy night in Mystacor.

Rare, but not impossible.

Yet Castaspella hadn't seen rain in Mystacor in all these years she had been out of the library.

So, for her, it was a rather impossible occurrence.

The women were preparing to go to bed, and Castaspella had just closed her book when she finally noticed.

—I didn't know it could rain up here…

—How did you- Oh, right— the Tyrant sighed. Leaning closer, she kissed the young sorceress' forehead and pointed out —You still have spent most of your life inside that library.

—Yeah, I have…

—I should apologize. It was my fault.

—I need you to stop apologizing for this— Castaspella replied, turning to face her.

—Why shouldn't I apologize? Don't tell me you don't like it…— Shadow Weaver questioned her, wrapping an arm around her waist and leaning forward.

—You've already apologized for it before. And if you start apologizing for everything at all times, it'll lose its strength and I'll have to think you don't really mean it.

With a hearty laugh that surprised them both, the Tyrant laid down and pulled Castaspella closer.

—I suppose you're right about that. But I still only apologize to you because you're *you*— she smirked.

—I would rather you learnt to apologize *at the right moment and time*, to whom it *corresponds*.

—Not going to happen any time soon.

—So I feared— Castaspella sighed, rolling her eyes.

Chuckling, the dark sorceress kissed her neck a few times.

—So, how is the new Queen of Mystacor feeling after her first week?

—Oh- I… I'm still getting used to it.

—Are you?

—Yes, um… The way people react to my presence now and all that… It's so strange.

—A good strange or a bad strange?

—A bit of each, to be honest— Castaspella admitted, resting her head on Shadow Weaver's chest. —I feel like some people fear me now, and I really don't like that. But… there are many others who trust me and now find me more reliable since I have real power within the Princess Alliance.

—Oh, I see…

—Does that annoy you?

—No… It's just curious— Shadow Weaver clarified.

—Good curious or bad curious?— Castaspella asked, making her smirk.

—Funny… But I don't know. Time will tell.

As expected, Castaspella's responsibilities began pilling up.

But, for the most part, that was related to her putting too many things in her to-do list.

She wanted to handle everything, not because she couldn't trust others with the tasks, but rather because she didn't want to "bother" others with those things.

The Tyrant could hardly believe *she* had better understanding of time-management sometimes.

But well, it'd be a question of time before Castaspella realized she must delegate tasks sometimes.

As expected, it wasn't long before a massive issue took relevance and pretty much forced the young Queen to focus her attention and delegate everything else to the Council.

A problem with Mystacor's water supply net.

Just great.

—We need to get external help for this.

—And who do you suggest?

—Well, the logical option would be to ask for the Princess of Salineas, Mermista— Castaspella replied.

—She's barely a kid— Shadow Weaver scoffed. —And I suppose the Council hasn't informed you of what her father thinks of me and Mystacor.

—She's quite skilled, despite being… twelve? In any case, I could try to make a deal with her father. If you let me try…

—Suddenly you *do* ask for permission?— the Tyrant sardonically laughed.

—I thought I needed it for this particular matter.

—Normally, I would just tell you to drop the idea, it's a lost cause, but if you really think you can get us her help… Well, it'll be you losing time.

—We've been without water in the upper levels for too long. The lower levels might flood… I *have* to try.

—Fine. You can go to Salineas and ask for an audience. Then you'll probably have to pray to the Stars— Shadow Weaver smirked. —He's quite intransigent.

—How do you know?

—He used to trade with Mystacor; mere-folk with magical potential would come to study here… Then *I* happened and he cut all relationships with the kingdom, forbidding his citizens from studying here anymore— the Tyrant casually explained.

—That doesn't sound good…

—I told you.

—I'll try anyways. Maybe I can improve the relationship between our kingdoms.

—Suit yourself.

Oh, she most absolutely would.

Getting to Salineas wouldn't be easy.

Granted, she could sail from Bright Moon to the kingdom, but would she even be allowed to set foot there?

She was very obviously from Mystacor, after all…

Maybe she could… ask Angella for a favour?

Surely she could get her a meeting with King Mercia as official regents of their respective kingdoms, right?

—He refuses.

—What!?

—I'm sorry, Casta. There isn't much I can do— Angella apologized.

—Why does he refuse?— Micah innocently asked.

—He won't see anyone related to Mystacor.

—So not even me?

—Not even you— she confirmed, trying to not laugh at her husband's dejected expression.

—Did you explain there're lives at risk!?

—I did, Casta. But he simply refuses to help Mystacor in any way.

—Only because of Shadow Weaver!?

—Yes…— Angella sighed.

—You do realize this is ridiculous, right!? What's the point of the alliance if we won't help each other between allies!?

—I *understand* what you mean, Casta, but what do you want me to do? I can't force him to help you!

—You can order him to grant me an audience. Whether I can convince him to help or not, that's up to me.

—I can't just order people around…

—You-you do. All day— Castaspella replied, baffled.

Indignant, Angella looked back at her husband, only to see him grimace at her, apologetic.

He agreed with his sister.

—*Fine*! I'll see if I can get him to grant you an audience. But I *cannot* intervene if he won't lend you his help.

—That's enough for me— the young sorceress assured her.

Eventually, Castaspella got the audience she had been asking for with King Mercia.

Hostility from him was expected, but the young woman felt confident. If she could deal with Shadow Weaver, how difficult could this guy be?

She'd soon find out…

The trip to Salineas was uneventful, a pair of guards received her upon arrival, and then she was taken to the throne room, where she was asked to wait for the king.

That was probably a display of power from him. Making her wait…

While Shadow Weaver would usually wait in the darkness for the arrival of whomever went to see her, King Mercia wanted his guests to see him make an entrance instead.

Different tactics best fitting each of their respective personae.

Fine.

That actually meant he was already giving Castaspella enough information to prepare.

She could guess from his tactic that the man ruled with a firm hand, but not exactly with fear like Shadow Weaver. Instead, he clearly wanted to show strength, to inspire respect, to have people know their place not by belittling them, but rather by subtle actions that would make them aware of the place where *he* considered they stood.

This also meant his ego was just as big as Shadow Weaver's, yet his ambitions probably didn't match hers. Plus, opposite to her, it was evident he very much cared about everyone's opinion of him. Most likely, he had several attires, each with carefully tailored messages intended to be made clear with a single look.

Vanity. That had to be Mercia's trait, just like pride was Shadow Weaver's.

Perfect.

Castaspella now had a profile.

And just in time, since the King finally deigned to appear.

—A sorceress of Mystacor— he began, approaching the throne with long, confident strides. —Never thought I would *ever* have to receive one of you here again…— he went on, sitting down with an air of severity. —Alas, I had no choice in the matter. The Queen of Bright Moon ordered as much. Being her sister-in-law must have its perks— he commented, smug.

Off to a great start…

Castaspella was immediately invaded by shame.

Probably his intention.

She knew as much, but she couldn't help the wave of insecurity that took over her.

Yet she couldn't back down. Not now.

She had to remember who she was now.

—King Mercia— she began, bowing respectfully. —I most certainly thank you for welcoming me, even if solely because the Queen ordered as much. But I must remind you that I came here in quality of Queen of Mystacor, not Angella's sister-in-law.

—You're far from welcome here, *sorceress*— he scoffed. —As for your title, I can hardly recognize it while that *Tyrant* rules the kingdom— he added, looking disgusted.

—What a shame— Castaspella sighed. —I understand many of your subjects were quite talented magicians… To think they now go untrained, stripped from the opportunity to reach

their full potential. It's quite unfortunate to have lost all diplomatic relationships.

—There's no use for diplomacy when a Tyrant is at the other end. The Princess Alliance wouldn't recognize her status if they weren't so desperate and helpless against the Horde.

—I thought you might say that— the young Queen replied, looking away. —Yet I can't help but wonder what your people think. Do they respect your decision, or consider it unwise? Have u ever thought about it, your Majesty?

Eyes wide, he was suddenly speechless.

No snarky remarks or smug rebukes.

Castaspella could practically see the doubt in his expression.

—I'm doing what's best for my people. Their wellbeing is my sole interest in this matter.

—Glad we have the same interest, then— she replied. —After all, the reason I ask for your help today is to keep my people safe. Their wellbeing depends on my capacity to actually *get* your help— she explained, serious. He seemed suddenly interested and allowed her to continue —Mystacor's water network seems to be suffering some kind of malfunction we can't figure out. The lower levels are at risk of flooding, while the upper levels have dried. Most of our food supply comes from our gardens, which are located in said upper levels… Flood and starvation threaten my people. I will not give up until I find a solution.

—The Queen said you wanted to request our help… but never mentioned why— he revealed. —What do you expect me to do?

—I believe your daughter possesses the power to fix our water network… Or at the very least find the problem so we can fix it ourselves— Castaspella explained.

—I cannot allow my daughter to go anywhere near the Tyrant.

—What if I promised to keep Shadow Weaver away?

—It's a risk I'm unwilling to take— he insisted. —She's my only daughter, far too young. I cannot entrust her safety to anyone. And I certainly can't trust she'll be safe in Mystacor.

—King Mercia, I…

—Enough, Castaspella— he interrupted her, albeit without anger or disdain. —I understand, I can empathize with your situation, but there's nothing I can do for you. Nothing I'm *willing* to do.

—I see…— she sighed, looking down. —Then I'm obligated to tell you that, when my people die, when the survivors are forced to abandon their homes and belongings, it'll be known that you refused to help. Our last hope…

With that, they young Queen turned to leave, fighting her tears and the lump in her throat.

She had failed.

Ashamed and sorrowful, she returned to Mystacor.

All she could do on the way there was think of a proper evacuation plan. Something that could save as many people as possible.

She'd have to chose who to save… But how could she?

And even if she *somehow* managed to evacuate everyone, where would she take all that people!?

She swallowed hard as she approached the cliff-side, step by step, and took a deep breath, readying to make her way up to the floating island.

However, before she could do as much, a voice called out behind her.

—Hey! Wait up!

—Huh?

Castaspella turned around only to find a young girl running towards her.

There was no mistaking her: King Mercia's daughter.

—Finally…

—Princess Mermista!?— she reacted. —Wha-what are you doing here!?

—I… heard you… talk to Dad… Ugh… I'm so… Ah…

—Alright, take a moment to recover your breath.

—I'm fine— the young teen replied. —I want to help— she finally said, standing straight. —You said I can do it. I wanna try.

—Your father…

—He won't know I'm gone until, like, a few hours— she dismissed her.

The sorceress found herself hesitating.

She needed her help, but accepting it would only provoke the King's wrath.

—Just… give me a moment to think.

—What's there to think!? You said people will die.

—But you're a teen. Your father has valid concerns…

—I'm already thirteen, okay!? I can do this.

—I know, I'm sure you can. But if anything happened to you…

—Nothing will happen— the Princess groaned. —Let's just go so I can return before Dad finds out.

—A-alright. But I need you to promise you will make sure to stay away from Shadow Weaver. I'll try to keep her occupied, of course, but if you see her, hide— she requested.

—Sure— Mermista smirked.

Without losing any more time, Castaspella went to find her fellow councillors.

With Mermista in tow, she let them know they had little time to check their water supply net and find the problem, but that she had to keep Shadow Weaver occupied so they would have to help the princess.

Hence, leaving the young teen in Daryon and Kenno's capable hands, Castaspella rushed to find the Tyrant.

—Where are you going at that speed?— the woman surprised her.

—Oh! The-there you are! I was looking for you…

—Were you? Or were you trying to hide from me?— she smirked.

—So you know…— Castaspella scoffed. —Listen…

—No, *you* listen— she interrupted her. —If King Mercia ever learns that his daughter came here against his wishes and *we allowed her* to help instead of sending her back, we'll have a huge problem in our hands.

—Ugh, so you know it *all*, don't you?

—Yes.

—Then make things easier for me and stay in your room. Let the princess work fast, and she'll be back before her father knows!

—And when they ask how we fixed our problem?— she insisted, with her usual condescending tone.

—We have no reasons to reply. Or explain ourselves.

—Smart— Shadow Weaver chuckled, quite proud. —This means we're both on the same page, so I'll let this pass. And… I'll stay in my room, don't worry.

—Thank you— Castaspella sighed, stepping closer. —I promise it'll be fine.

—I don't need you to promise that. But I most certainly hope, *for your own good*, that everything does turn out fine in the end…

Chapter End Notes

Well, that was all for today! I love this chapter so much!! I'm so proud of Casta, tbh... and next chapter? Oof she's amazing >^<

Alright, so, see you next week on Monday!
Thanks for reading!!

Chapter 7

Chapter Summary

> "Now, go, before that pitiful excuse of a king declares war on us or something" ~ SW

Chapter Notes

> Oh yes!
> Midnight has come!! Here I am with a newwww chapterrrrr!!!
>
> This is an interesting chapter, and for my soft-hearted readers, you're very lucky today's Monday and not Thursday XD
> You won't have to wait much for the next chapter lol
>
> AAAAANYWAYS!!
>
> Please enjoy!!

See the end of the chapter for more notes



Fortunately for Mystacor, the Princess of Salineas was extremely capable and managed to fix the water supply network of the island soon enough.

Unfortunately for Castaspella, King Mercia still found out his thirteen-years-old daughter escaped and acted against his wishes…

It was true that Shadow Weaver had already stated she would not take responsibility… But it still annoyed the young sorceress.

—We'll have a long chat when I'm back. Understood?— Castaspella sternly told her, before leaving for Bright Moon.

—Sure…

—I'm serious!

—I *know*! Now, go, before that pitiful excuse of a king declares war on us or something.

Castaspella arrived at Bright Moon just in time, rushing a bit, and walked into the throne room where Mercia expressed his "concerns".

—…So, not only must I remind you how *undeserving of trust* that Tyrant is, but also I have to consider all those magicians to be just as untrustworthy!

—King Mercia…

—Excuse me, Queen Angella, but I won't change my mind.

—That's a shame— Castaspella said, voice firm. —I hoped to thank you, but if you think I'd be insincere, then I better save my breath.

—Thank me!? You *used* my daughter!

—Your daughter has more conscience than you and offered her help!

—Moment! Please, both of you— Angella stopped them. —Can we move to a different room and discuss this in private?

—Why private?— Castaspella asked, confused.

—Because these matters clearly call for some better diplomacy.

—You fear I'll declare war on Mystacor?— Mercia laughed. —Or just that I'll piss off that Tyrant!? Are you so scared of her, your Majesty?

—Enough— she silenced him, glaring intensely. —Both of you, follow me.

Briefly exchanging a glance, the regents followed the Queen of the Rebellion into what they supposed was her office. Once inside, the three remained standing even though there were more than enough chairs.

—This is simple— Mercia began. —I want there to be consequences for what happened. I want that Tyrant to *pay*.

—For what!? She did *nothing*! She didn't even *see* Mermista!— Castaspella complained.

—Then should *you* pay for it!?

—Pay for *what*!?— the sorceress insisted. —I did *not* force your daughter to do anything! I didn't even talk to her until she found me at the edge of the cliff on the way to Mystacor!

—Alright, alright. Enough— Angella interceded. —King Mercia, I can understand why you feel that your daughter was put in danger, but you must admit Mermista made her choice and went to Mystacor out of her own volition to help— she began. —On the other hand, Castaspella, you must understand that, while you didn't force the Princess to go to Mystacor, you shouldn't have let her into the island…

—And let my people die!? Do you think I didn't consider what could happen!? Do you think I wasn't expecting this!?

—Casta…

—For fuck's sake! I had little time to weight the pros and cons! And my conclusion was simple: lives would be *lost*. I very much rather sit here to argue with you two the rest of my life than let a single soul in that island die under my watch!— the young Queen blurted out, afraid to be interrupted if she spoke any slower.

—I see— Angella sighed. She then looked at King Mercia and asked —What do you think?

—As I told you yesterday, I can empathize with your problem— he began. —But my daughter went there alone, and…

—If you had agreed to let her help us, you could have sent her with all the security you deemed necessary— Castaspella pointed out, joining her hands behind her back, under the cape.

—But…

—I need you to understand that, by refusing to help us, *you* caused this. Your daughter eavesdropped and heard she could help us save our people. She decided to defy you for a greater good— she insisted. —I did what I could to, at least, respect your wishes to make sure she wouldn't come across Shadow Weaver, but it would have been better if you had approved of her mission and laid out what you considered the necessary security.

—Tha-that's… No-no. I won't allow you to shift blame onto me— King Mercia reacted, after a few seconds of shock.

—I am not. I'm explaining to you that there was a better way of doing things…

—Listen: I just want to make sure this won't repeat. I cannot trust you since you simply let my daughter do as she pleased instead of sending her back home— he insisted.

—And I'm telling you Princess Mermista did what was best for the people of a different kingdom, because she cares about the people of Etheria— Castaspella pointed out. —Can't you recognize it as your daughter being a good fit for ruler of Salineas one day?

—What if her selfless behaviour for other kingdoms makes her instead neglect her own!?

—Your Majesty, you can't seriously think she would be such poor judge of a situation…

—She's a teen!

—Alright, stop— Angella interceded. —This conversation is going nowhere— she sighed. —And yelling won't get us anywhere either— she added. —So, King Mercia. You ask for Mystacor to pay for a… nondescript transgression. And for guarantees that it won't happen again. What exactly are you asking for? A formal apology?

—I want… Uh… I-I just want my kid to be safe, alright?— he finally stuttered, looking down.

Silence.

The Queen no longer knew what to say.

But Castaspella did.

—Of course, I understand— she began. —I would never endanger anyone. I *know* Shadow Weaver can be a threat, I'm aware. So, I can absolutely promise you that I didn't and won't ever let her close to your daughter.

King Mercia fell silent.

Looking away, he pondered for a second before letting out a long sigh.

—It's quite confusing to hear you talk about that Tyrant like this when… uh, when you're…

—I know— the sorceress interrupted, smiling amusedly at his flustered behaviour. —I believe it's normal to be confused.

—In any case…— he sighed. —I suppose I overreacted a bit, after all. No harm was done, and… in fact, much harm was prevented.

—Indeed— Castaspella nodded.

As he nodded too, she took a step forward and extended her hand to shake his.

—I'm glad to know you're a regent of Mystacor too— he said, firmly shaking her hand. —Maybe, one day, I'll let my people return there to learn.

Having successfully handled the matter with King Mercia, Castaspella returned to Mystacor in a good mood.

Which didn't last long.

—Finally back? And you're not crying… I'm guessing it somehow went well?

—Wha-what do you mean- Why are you being such a bitch!?— the young sorceress reacted, slamming the door behind her. —I just barely put a foot in the room and you…

—Nothing out of the ordinary from me— the Tyrant dismissively replied.

—I *just* come back from solving a problem *you* should have solved! You and your behaviour are what got us in this mess with Salineas!

—Oh, how terrible…

—People could have died! If Princess Mermista hadn't gone against her father's wishes and helped us…

—I know. So, what?— Shadow Weaver interrupted, looking disinterested as she rested against the back of her chair.

—You cannot just dismiss this matter…

—I can, and will. It's solved now.

—Not thanks to you!

—What a problem… If you don't like it, you can always leave— she taunted her, sardonic.

Rolling her eyes, the Tyrant returned to the papers on her desk, sure Castaspella would just give up and go to have a bath or something.

But she did not.

Shadow Weaver heard the door, and just like that, the young Queen was gone.

Where the heck was she going!?

Her room wasn't there anymore! It's a storage room now!

Great…

Maybe that meant she'd return to sleep? After all, where else could she go?

Maybe Bright Moon?

It didn't matter now.

The Tyrant would find out later…

It was dinner time soon enough, and the old woman ate alone.

Then a few hours passed and still, there was no sign of Castaspella.

That woman…

Fine! She'll go look for her! Why not!

Exasperated, the Tyrant left her room and headed to Bright Moon.

However, she was surprised to learn that Castaspella wasn't there.

Micah suggested she could have gone with some friend, but even he didn't know many friends of hers…

Shadow Weaver would have to do some digging.

Just earlier, unbeknownst to the Tyrant, Castaspella had actually been struggling with this matter.

She didn't want to go to Bright Moon since she loathed having to explain what happened with the old woman, so Micah's guess was correct.

She tried to go with a friend.

But…

—Hey… So sorry to bother you, but…

—Ca-Casta!?

An acolyte about her age and height had opened the door of her room and now stared in shock at the young Queen of Mystacor.

—Sorry, I know we haven't talked in a while, but I really need help.

—My help? That's… unexpected— the woman replied, confused. —What can I help you with?

—I-I need- I need a place to stay for the night— she explained, stammering and unable to hold her sight.

—Wait, what!? You have to be kidding me— her "friend" said. —I can't possibly receive you here. You should know that. You belong to the Tyrant now.

—Excuse you!? I don't *belong* to anyone.

—Well, you're her partner, whatever. It still means she will kill me if she so much as thinks I touched you or something— the acolyte insisted.

—So, that's a no.

—I can't take the risk, Casta. Sorry…

The night had gotten much darker since then, and now the Tyrant wanted to find her partner as soon as possible, before the temperature dropped any further.

After asking many people at the library, those who frequented it the most, Shadow Weaver managed to gather enough information about Castaspella's past relationships. Everything pointed at *one* specific friend she'd surely go to for help, so that was the place to begin.

Soon, the Tyrant was at the door of the acolyte many had referred to as the last partner Castaspella had had a few years earlier…

—Who is it now- Oh, shit!

—"Oh, shit", indeed— Shadow Weaver smirked. —Where is she?

—Not here— the woman stammered.

—Really?

—Yes! I told her I couldn't receive her. I-I…

—You sent her off? You left her to, what? Sleep on the ground tonight? What a friend you are…

—No, no. I didn't mean to- I just couldn't- I didn't want to…— the acolyte stammered.

—Didn't want to make me angry, no? Funny, that's exactly what you've managed— the dark sorceress replied. —Yes, she's my partner. And *you* have sent her away, left her to her devices when she needed your help.

—But…

—I *am* now angry, because if *anything* happened to her, it was *your fault*— the Tyrant snarled.

—I-I'm so sorry…

—Listen— the Tyrant interrupted her. —If you know Castaspella as much as you supposedly do, then you should be aware of how fragile her heart can be. And you still decided to reject her?

—You can't be saying…

—I am saying it. Some friend you are… I should make you suffer for what you've done.

—Wait… I-I didn't…

—Silence— Shadow Weaver interrupted. —If you don't want to be punished, then tell me everything you know about Castaspella's places. Where would she go if she had nowhere else?

—I-if she's not in Bright Moon, or the library, then… ma-maybe the beach? She loves it…

—Not the best place to spend the night…

—She did mention sometimes that she likes the peace there and wouldn't mind sleeping at the beach.

—Worth checking, I suppose— the Tyrant admitted, pensive. —Alright. I'm letting you off the hook this once, and for her. Count yourself lucky and be more thankful next time you see her. Am I clear?

—Ye-yes, Tyrant. I'm sorry…

—I'm not the one you should apologize to— she scoffed, before turning around and stalking away.

—Su-sure…

The beach of Mystacor was certainly the most peaceful place. Other than the Steam Grotto.

But it was also… quite cold.

And yet, there she was.

Sitting near the cloud-waves, curled up, hugging her legs against her chest.

—There you are…— Shadow Weaver let out, relieved.

—Huh!? What- Why are you here?

—I've been looking for you everywhere, woman. Why do you think I'm here?

—She told you- Wait, you went to…

—Yes. I found your ex…

—Never officially my partner, so no ex— Castaspella interrupted, resting her chin on her knees and looking back at the cloud-waves coming and going.

—Oh, is that so? So she was just a terrible friend, no?

—You could say so… Or… Wasn't, but is now— she sighed.

—Why don't you tell me, then?

—We were just friends with benefits. That's all. If you have nothing else to talk about, you can leave— the young Queen let out.

—I actually have more to talk about— Shadow Weaver replied, sitting next to her.

—Speak.

—What is the matter? Why…

—You haven't realized?

—I'm asking you because I don't know. What do you want me to do? Are you angry?

—I'm- Of course! But angry isn't really the word. I'm disappointed! I'm frustrated! I'm just… Ugh! You suck sometimes!

—Seriously?

—You're so- I don't know how to explain it! You can be the best and the worst person ever! At the same time!

—Fine, then tell me…

—You want to know what's the problem!? We had a crisis! You did nothing! I did what I could, and that got us into another problem, and *again* you did nothing! Like, ugh! Couldn't you make an effort, at the very least, to fucking help!?

—What did you want me to do!? *You* could solve it! *I* couldn't! What the heck was I supposed to do!?

—The fact that you have to ask, that you don't know the answer to that question despite it being so simple, is part of the problem!

—Well, I cannot solve this if I don't know the answer!

—Make an effort! Spare a thought for someone other than yourself! What were you supposed to do? Something! Anything! Ask, at the very least, what you can do! Literally anything other than mocking me first thing as soon as I walk in!

—You're still mad about that!?

—Of fucking course I am!

—I was trying to…

—Don't even- No. Don't make up excuses. It was very shitty of you. That's it.

—Yes, it was…

—Good that you can admit it.

—So… You want me to apologize, is that it? Because you know I can't do that easily. You told me I was apologizing too much to you; what I understood was that I was doing it wrong, and I *don't* know any other way. I simply suck at apologizing.

—I *know* you do. But it would be nice if you still tried…

—It's ridiculous, Casta.

—It is not. Can't you do it for me, at least?

—I- Well, I mean… I don't know how.

—Then think about it. Find a way. Then maybe we can talk.

—You're… not coming back to the room, are you?

—No.

—I see…

—I want my old room back, alright?

—Sure. But, for tonight, go with your brother, at least. Can you? I'll order the room to be cleared out so you can return there whenever you need— Shadow Weaver accepted. —You can… take your time.

—Thank you. I hope you'll take the time to reflect too, and eventually find it within you to apologize. Or I'm not returning.

The Tyrant felt suddenly… cornered.

But she was right.

—Of course. I understand. I'll leave you in peace, then.

—I'll go to Bright Moon.

—Please.

—Find me when you figure out how to apologize.

—I will— Shadow Weaver promised, smirking.

With that, the regents of Mystacor farewelled, each went their own way, and didn't see each other again until the Tyrant was ready to apologize…

Or try.

Chapter End Notes

:D

Sorry!!

I hope you enjoyed the chapter, MANY thanks for reading, and see you in a couple of days!! ^_^

Chapter 8

Chapter Summary

After the first few years *trying* to make Castaspella be this paranoid, this scared, and constantly on the verge of breaking, and *never* managing it, why was it happening *now*!?

Just her luck…

The woman who refused to let fear dominate her, the woman who would hold her sight and bark back at her… was now a mess. And not a pretty mess.

This wasn't fun…

Chapter Notes

Welp, today marks one month exactly since my b-day
Very glad to e be here with you, guys :D

Now comes an interesting chapter, I promise, but there will also be better ones…

My "rush hour" begins now too since I only have written until ch 13, none edited, and keep struggling to begin with ch14…
But Hey! I'll manage, I'm sure :D

So now, please enjoy!!

See the end of the chapter for more notes



Eventually, much to the Tyrant's relief, Castaspella returned.

Of course it took some… work behind the scenes, but she managed it.

It felt physically painful, it was pathetic, but Shadow Weaver actually apologized to the young Queen in an admissible manner.

Good…

And just in time.

Castaspella's twenty-fifth birthday was nigh, and her brother wanted to organize a surprise party with his wife.

Well, sure, why not.

But why did Shadow Weaver have to handle keeping the secret!? She didn't really like parties or celebrating birthdays, yet… they invited her.

Ugh…

It was annoying, for the most part.

It *should* be a simple task, except for the fact that Castaspella actually seemed to suspect!?

The Tyrant was going insane trying to figure out what had the sorceress so paranoid without revealing the secret birthday party…

And she was miserably failing.

She wanted to scream into the void half the time.

So, so annoying!

Well, whatever, she didn't have time for this.

She'll have to… to what?

She could do nothing!

Castaspella wouldn't calm down without Shadow Weaver revealing the only secret she was keeping!

Since when was the Tyrant so incapable of keeping something under wraps!?

Whatever! Who cared!?

She should just tell her and forget about the whole surprise factor.

Maybe she could tell Castaspella to pretend she didn't know?

Ugh, who was she kidding!?

She'd ruin it all for her…

Well, in that case, maybe she could just… make Castaspella talk and elaborate all her theories?

Something, *anything* that would let Shadow Weaver divert the sorceress' attention until it was time for the party at last.

Anything to delay revealing it until it's *time*!

Whatever…

But…

She had no idea.

Well, how convenient…

The one time she needed her skills to bullshit her way through a problem, she simply couldn't.

Ugh!

Shadow Weaver was going insane. So exasperating!

Just let her talk, let her talk…

Let Castaspella focus on anything else…

That was the plan.

The young Queen was on her way back to Shadow Weaver's room when she felt a chill run down her spine.

Again.

This was the third or fourth time this same day.

What was happening!?

She had no idea, but she felt so scared…

She couldn't stop to think. She simply ran down the corridor.

Castaspella rushed to the door and got inside, closed behind her and let out a long sigh.

—What's wrong?

—Ah! Shit, you almost killed me!

—Did I?

Shadow Weaver seemed genuinely confused, enough that it made the young Queen blush.

Oops.

—So-sorry, no. I mean, yeah, but it's my fault.

—What is it now, scaredy-cat?— the old woman asked, smirking sardonically.

—Hey!

—Just tell me what's wrong.

—I felt… like, a chill. I felt observed, you know?

—Oh? Really?

—Yes. I-I don't know what's going on…

Suddenly it occured to her… that maybe Castaspella wasn't suspicious or anything.

Maybe she wasn't paranoid because she thought Shadow Weaver was hiding something, but rather, something *else* made her feel this way?

—I see…— the Tyrant sighed.

—Look, I *know* I sound insane, but I swear there's something!

—Something like what?

—I-I don't know! If I knew I wouldn't be so scared!

—Right… And what is this something supposed to be doing? Or want to do?

—I don't know?

—Then why are you scared?

—What if it jumps on me!?

—If *what* jumps on you?

—Whatever that is!

Shadow Weaver let out a long sigh.

—So you don't know *what* is out there, what it wants or doesn't want, or if this *something* exists at all, but you're convinced it might jump on you?

—Yes…

—Does that sound sane to you?

—No.

—Then what am I supposed to do?

—Can't you just… I-I don't know… Calm me down?

—I'm trying. I'm making you rationalize all of this so you realize how stupid it is to be scared…

—Well, it's *not* helping!

—I *realize*— Shadow Weaver grunted, resting down on her chair. —Come here…

—What?— Castaspella asked, albeit complying.

—Just come, sit with me.

—Where?

—On my lap?— she proposed, smirking.

—Don't try to distract me like that…

—Why not?— the Tyrant asked, holding Castaspella close as she did, in fact, sit on her lap.

—Be-because this is serious!

—What if it's not so serious?

—I-I mean…

—It might just be in your head. Whatever you're so afraid of…

—And if it's not…

—What do you think might be scaring you so much?

—I don't know!— Castaspella insisted.

—Look, for some reason, you're scared. Of nothing in particular, hence, of everything. And that's unhealthy.

—Unhealthy?

—It makes you paranoid, constantly looking around you and expecting something to jump… That's wearing you out…

—Yeah, I'm exhausted…

—Then calm down, at least now.

—But…

—I'm just- Listen, with me here, nothing can jump on you, so take this moment to rest.

—Alright, alright. I will. Tha-thank you.

—Of course…

—Ah…

Shadow Weaver took a deep breath and held Castaspella against her body. The young Queen rested her head on the Tyrant's shoulder and little by little dozed off, even if not entirely.

—I can't make many promises, but I can swear I won't let anything harm you… ever again.

—Ever again…

—Yes.

—Really, thank you— Castaspella repeated, her voice weaker. —And I'm sorry for acting like this. I don't know what's happening.

—I wish I knew. It's been days and your paranoia is only getting worse.

—Yeah…

—Have you been getting any sleep?

—A bit, yes?— the sorceress nodded. —But, it's always shallow.

—I imagined…

—What about you?

—I've been sleeping more than you, it seems— Shadow Weaver laughed.

—Yeah…

—Just rest now, then… We'll see later if we can find what's the problem…

—Do you think there really is something out there? I'm not insane?— Castaspella asked, eyes closed.

—You're not insane, but there might not be anything out there…

—So?

—So… something that may be nothing is probably triggering you in some way. I will find it and get rid of it. I swear.

—You said you couldn't promise many things…

—But I can promise you that— the Tyrant assured her. —Just don't lose your mind before I manage it— she added, smirking.

—I'll try. But I don't know… I don't… If I don't get enough sleep, I might just lose it.

Unfortunately the days prior to her birthday were only worse.

Shadow Weaver didn't think it could possibly happen, but there they were.

Castaspella began failing everything she attempted to do; being constantly stressed, it was no surprise.

But adding frustration to the paranoia was the last thing they needed.

The Tyrant was so confused, however.

After the first few years *trying* to make Castaspella be this paranoid, this scared, and constantly on the verge of breaking, and *never* managing it, why was it happening *now*!?

Just her luck…

The woman who refused to let fear dominate her, the woman who would hold her sight and bark back at her… was now a mess. And not a pretty mess.

This wasn't fun…

On the contrary, Shadow Weaver was starting to suffer herself seeing Castaspella like this.

And one thing became clear: She couldn't leave the young sorceress on her own.

This meant she couldn't go to Bright Moon and explain what was happening to Castaspella.

Hence, she would have to take her to the surprise party… and deal with however she reacted.

All Shadow Weaver could do was be there to make sure she wouldn't collapse.

How incredible…

In all her power, in all her might… she was powerless to help this woman when she really wanted to.

She never thought this day would come…

Hours before the arranged time, Shadow Weaver was holding Castaspella close to her, both laying in bed.

The young sorceress was shaking.

—How do you feel?

—How… do you think?— Castaspella sobbed.

—It was not your fault…

—It was! I-I-I can't do… *anything*!

—You can… You just need to calm down and focus…

—I can't.

—Then I want you to abstain from doing anything until you manage it— Shadow Weaver told her. —Once you feel better, once this all passes, then you can maybe return to your activities.

—But…

—No buts. You were lucky that vial exploding didn't get you or someone else hurt.

—I… I can't do *nothing* all day…

—I'm not saying that. I'm telling you to take a few days off.

—I can't…

—That's an order.

—What am I supposed to do, then?

—What about spending a few days with your brother?

—I don't want to be away from you…

—Casta…— she sighed. —It's for your own good. You need to…

—I just need to be here!

—No— Shadow Weaver insisted. —You need to get yourself together, and I clearly *suck* at helping you with that.

—I'll be fine…

—No, you won't. You're twenty-five and behaving like a six-year-old kid.

—Twenty-four…

—No.

—Huh?

—What day is today?

—I don't know!

—Casta— Shadow Weaver insisted, now pushing her back to make her look at her. —Today's your birthday, and you *forgot*.

—I… forgot… today… Oh, my— Castaspella muttered, sitting straight. —I'm sorry…

—Don't apologize.

—But I…

—Casta, listen to me: Let's go to Bright Moon. Yes? I'm sure seeing your brother will help you, so let's just go, and then we can see how you're feeling. If you're more comfortable there, you can stay a few days, it will probably help.

—And if I don't?

—If you don't, we'll just have to return here, and… find a way to solve this— Shadow Weaver sighed. —I have ran out of ideas, but I will rather tear everything down than see you suffer like this any longer.

—Thank you— the young sorceress sobbed, hugging her tightly. —I wish I knew what's happening.

—I wish so too…

As they arrived at the palace of Bright Moon, Castaspella kept holding onto Shadow Weaver like before, but seemed much calmer, and at least appeared to be relaxed and careless.

Either she was acting much tougher there than in Mystacor, or she was truly more at ease than in the island.

Could there seriously be some threat in Mystacor?

Shadow Weaver had no time to dwell on it since they arrived at the dinning room.

—Why here? The door's closed.

—The guards said they were waiting for you here…

—Oh…— Castaspella uttered. —Right.

—I'll open, you can stay behind me if you feel unsafe.

—N-no, no. I-I'm fine.

—Alright. Let's open, then— the Tyrant sighed, knowing full well what would *most likely* happen.

Taking a deep breath, the old woman pushed the doors open, and right on cue, Micah, Angella, and a bunch of people Shadow Weaver didn't know screamed in unison.

—Surprise!

Great…

Castaspella immediately jumped in fear and latched onto the Tyrant, burying her face behind her.

The poor woman had *never* gripped her that tight before.

Which was saying a lot…

—It's alright, Casta…

—Sis? Are you okay?

—What?— Castaspella muttered, daring to look into the chamber, very obviously prepared for a birthday celebration. —What… is this?

—It's your birthday, Casta— Angella reminded her.

—Oh…

—What happened?

—I wish I knew— Shadow Weaver groaned, giving Micah a tired look. —Trust me this once: I don't know.

—I'm so sorry, this is beautiful— Castaspella finally said, sobbing and slowly letting go of the Tyrant. —I-I… Oh, my… Thank you all— she expressed.

—Are you sure you're alright, Sis?— Micah insisted. —Come here— he invited her, arms open to embrace her.

Shadow Weaver looked back at her, and nodded as encouragingly as she could.

Castaspella took a deep breath and went to hug her brother.

She was relaxing.

Little by little.

Good…

The Tyrant observed for a bit as she was greeted by everyone, and considered leaving her in their surely-capable hands, but the sorceress soon returned to her.

—Can you stay?

—Are you sure?

—Please.

—I guess I can…— Shadow Weaver sighed. —But I won't speak to anyone.

—You don't have to.

—I could instead be checking for whatever is scaring you in Mystacor, you know…

—I don't need that. We-we'll fix that when we return.

—Casta…

—I just want you to stay with me, please.

—Alright, alright— the Tyrant gave up.

Chapter End Notes

And that was all for this week!!!

See you again on moday, I hope, and many many thanks for reading!! >v<

Chapter 9

Chapter Summary

> The moment Castaspella and Daryon arrived at the castle, they didn't know it but the Queen of Snows was watching…

Chapter Notes

> OwO new chapter!!!
>
> Ahem! Hi, welcome again! We're already in ch 9! Meaning we're past half the fic and only 3 weeks away from the end!!! :D
>
> So! What do we have today? Oh, yes! Frosta's mom!! She's amazing, I love her… She has little time in this fic, but in part 3 there's more of her!! hehe
>
> Anyways! No more delaying!
> Please enjoy!

See the end of the chapter for more notes



A few weeks went by before Castaspella managed to relax and return to her routine.

But, fortunately, all the hard work to find *what* was triggering the young sorceress so much eventually paid off.

A pesky little creature was found lurking around in corridors and chambers. Something with wings and a pointy tail.

Something very clearly belonging to the Horde.

Oh, that poor creature.

It barely managed to escape before Shadow Weaver could obliterate it.

But at least it meant Castaspella was right! There *was* something stalking her, observing and ready to pounce.

And now it was gone.

—So… We're sure everything's safe now?— Castaspella asked, remaining at the table in the council room after her fellow councillors left.

—Of course not— the Tyrant scoffed. —There's just one threat less, but we're still far from safe.

—That's not reassuring— the young sorceress muttered.

—I'm not trying to be— she replied, standing up and leaving the shadowed back of the room. —I'd much rather be honest.

—Sure— Castaspella sighed, rolling her eyes.

—Why are you still here?— Shadow Weaver then asked, reaching the table and resting her hands on it, leaning forward in front of the sorceress.

—We need to talk about the invitation from the Queen of Snows which you've been pointedly ignoring— she explained, smirking. —Did you think I wouldn't bring it up?

—I hoped so.

—What a shame— Castaspella mocked her. —Listen, it's important to attend this time. She wants to make an official cooperation agreement. And we could *definitely* use an ally like the Kingdom of Snows.

—Hmm… True— she hummed, pretending to consider it. —Truly a shame, then…

—Come on!

—I'm not leaving Mystacor.

—Love, please…— Castaspella pleaded, earning a probably annoyed look behind the mask. —Bea, I'm serious.

—If you think it's so important, then *you* can go.

—But…

—But what? You're the Queen of Mystacor. You can seal this deal in my stead, no?

—I-it's not the same! She's inviting you specifically!

—You'll have to tell her I'm sending *you*— Shadow Weaver insisted, looking away.

—Do you want me to go for any reason in particular?

—If I could, I'd send Daryon alone, but he's useless… they all are, without you to guide them — the Tyrant replied.

—Is that it? Or do you want me to *leave* Mystacor?

—No. I actually would prefer to ignore the invitation. I'm telling you to go because *you* insist it's necessary.

—Alright…— Castaspella accepted with a sigh.

—Were you thinking I wanted you away?

—Maybe…

—What's wrong now?

—No-nothing…— the sorceress muttered, standing from the table and trying to leave. However, Shadow Weaver quickly got between her and the door. —Hey!

—Tell me the truth.

—Really, it's nothing. I'm just over-thinking things.

—As you usually do. But why is it upsetting you now?

—*Because* your coldness is starting to make me doubt! Happy!?— Castaspella finally admitted.

—I should have known…

—Yeah, you should! So, *I* should be asking you what's wrong now!

She hesitated for a moment before reminding herself Castaspella is *safe* to be honest with, and sighed deeply.

—What happened the last couple of weeks… I-it made me feel too… *vulnerable*. Your state was affecting me more than it should have— the Tyrant explained, turning around.

—You were worried about me, Love— she reminded her, gently placing a hand on her shoulder. —And if you hadn't been, maybe you wouldn't have been so invested on finding out the cause, and we wouldn't have found that… that *imp* of the Horde!

—That doesn't matter! What matters is that I was out of sorts as if *I* were the one paranoid!

—Is this again about how I have "power over you" or whatever!?

—Obviously.

—Bea, please… You know I would never…

—It's not about what *you* would do.

—It's about what others could do to me, to get to you, I know…

—*Again*.

—Listen to me: it won't happen again. And even if it did, you're not that easy to take down. In fact, I think you're far more dangerous when angry. If they tried to hurt me again to indirectly harm you… Well, we all know what happened to the last two who did— Castaspella reminded her, smirking despite herself.

That made her consider it.

She wasn't wrong.

—True.

—Then let's take the night off and we'll see what we do about the invitation of the Kingdom of Snows… tomorrow.

—Fine…— Shadow Weaver grumbled.

The next morning, the sorceresses were lying in bed together, enjoying a few more minutes before having to get up.

As Castaspella let out a deep sigh, her head still lying on the Tyrant's chest, the old woman tightened her embrace on her.

—What's worrying you?

—Huh?

—You always hug me tighter when something's worrying you…

—Nothing— Shadow Weaver first replied, before thinking better about it. Castaspella would surely insist until she told her, so she finally admitted —I don't know if I can trust Daryon with your security. I would much rather you stayed here… but since you insist, the best option is to have you go and just keep an eye on you from here. That way, there's at least a chance for me to do *something*, while, if I were to travel in your stead, I'd have no idea what's happening with you here. *And*, if we went there together, Mystacor would likely collapse…

Ignoring the "joke", Castaspella pointed out —You've been giving it a lot of thought.

—Indeed, which is annoying— the Tyrant scoffed.

—I appreciate it— the sorceress sighed, closing her eyes. —And will also appreciate it if you help us prepare for the trip— she added, giggling.

—Right…— Shadow Weaver groaned. —Not like I have anything else to do.

After breakfast, preparations began.

Daryon looked nervous, and he had reasons to be.

The way the dark sorceress kept looking at him was… quite unnerving. Knowing his Master, that was a warning.

He tried to focus on loading the horse he'd be riding, but he could still feel her eyes on his back.

Fortunately, Castaspella soon claimed her attention.

—I'll ask one last time: are you sure you want me to go? Wouldn't you want to come with me instead, maybe?

—As I told you, I refuse to leave Mystacor.

—Why? You can't really think the island would collapse!

—I can't leave the council unsupervised. Trust me.

—That's mean— the young sorceress reproached her. —But I guess I can't convince you. However, you better behave these three days, alright?

—Shouldn't it be two days?— Shadow Weaver asked, sounding confused.

—The trip takes half a day on horseback, so it's a whole day just to go and return— Castaspella pointed out.

—Wouldn't you rather I help you teleport there?

—And pray tell, how would we return?

—Right— the Tyrant uttered.

Castaspella could almost *see* her rolling her eyes behind the mask.

—Alright… Time to go.

—Get ready while I speak with Daryon. He'll join you soon— Shadow Weaver ordered, leaving to speak with him. As she approached the councilman, she made sure to look as menacing as possible, and smirked when he jumped, startled at her sudden appearance behind him. —Daryon…

—Ye-yes, Master?

—Listen carefully: I am entrusting you with Castaspella's safety. You *must* make sure no harm comes to her.

—Of course.

—And if you dare lay a hand on her, I'll chop it off— she finally threatened, towering over him.

—I-I would *never* dare do such a thing!— he assured her. —You have my word.

—Good. Then you may leave.

The moment Castaspella and Daryon arrived at the castle, they didn't know it but the Queen of Snows was watching…

And the first thing she noticed, was the young sorceress' black lips.

Squinting, she considered for a moment whether it was worth granting her the audience she had expected Shadow Weaver to attend… But perhaps it wasn't so different to receive her than the Tyrant herself.

And according to her subjects, Castaspella was even a better option than the old woman. Easier to talk to, to negotiate with… to reason with.

So the Queen decided to give this new *Queen of Mystacor* a chance.

Castaspella and Daryon got a nice welcome from the people of Snows.

Knowing how long the trip was, they didn't hesitate to take their horses to be cared for, and immediately took them to their assigned bedrooms so they could rest.

The meeting with the Queen of Snows would be the following day, so it'd be better if they could sleep well and prepare for it the next morning.

They were also offered dinner that night, a few hours after arrival, during which they could privately discuss how they would handle the audience with the Queen.

—I think we need to put emphasis on how much Shadow Weaver has changed her behaviour, or… well, more like calmed down with the citizens since we're handling problems ourselves before they reach her— Castaspella suggested.

—I agree. Since the Queen of Snows wanted her to attend, I suppose she was expecting to assess her behaviour— Daryon replied. —That may be a problem for us.

—Yes, that's what I meant— she nodded. —I am hoping our word will be enough. Also guaranteeing we're doing everything we can to improve the atmosphere in Mystacor, and will take responsibility to keep our side of the cooperation agreement.

—What if she wants to send people of hers to train at Mystacor? Can we really make sure they won't be threatened by Shadow Weaver?

—We can promise that and take as many precautions as possible to fulfill that promise— the young sorceress confidently assured.

—Ah… Alright. Let's go with that strategy then— Daryon sighed, smiling faintly but trusting her fully.

Neither of them could really sleep much that night. Both were so worried about the outcome… Daryon feared failure and how the Tyrant would react, while Castaspella refused to fail and cost Mystacor such a powerful ally.

However, they were still up early to get ready and have breakfast before the meeting.

Then, they anxiously waited for the Queen of Snows to show up, barely able to hide their nervousness.

—Good morning— a voice finally greeted them, as a petite woman with pitch-black hair walked into the throne room, flanked by guards. —I apologize for making you wait. My child is still a baby and quite unpredictable…

Hiding her surprise, since Castaspella had no idea this woman had a kid, she simply smiled —That's completely understandable, Your Majesty. No need to apologize.

The Queen seemed to halt for a second, the corner of her mouth twitching upwards, yet it was too brief; she soon reached her throne, and made no further comments on the matter.

Instead, she went directly to the core question.

—I believe we should start then. We have a few topics to discuss, and I'd rather this doesn't extend further than today— she sighed. —Since I was *not* granted the presence of the Tyrant herself, I must ask: Why are you two here instead?

As Daryon looked at her, Castaspella answered —I regret to inform you that Shadow Weaver didn't want to attend at all, or send anyone either. I had to insist this was important, a good opportunity for Mystacor, and that's why we're here. According to her, as Queen of Mystacor, I have enough authority to seal the agreement you offer, and of course, I brought Daryon along since he's the foreman-councilman.

—I see— the woman nodded. —Normally, I would take offense, but since you're the one who decided to respect my invitation, I'll refrain from taking it out on you. However, I suppose you know that it won't be easy to seal this deal after all… Not without being able to have a proper understanding of how the Tyrant is as an individual.

—Of course, Your Majesty— Daryon nodded.

—We expected as much, yes. I believe it's only natural to be wary in this case— the sorceress admitted. —So we shall make our best effort to convey how she currently behaves, and anything you may want to know.

—I appreciate that— the Queen sighed. —I am told your name is Castaspella, correct?

—Yes.

—I know your brother, but I don't know you. And I must admit I'm quite intrigued that someone your age, so polite and respectful, managed to reach the position of Queen— she went on.

—I-I can assure you, Your Majesty, that she earned it— Daryon immediately clarified.

—Calm down, I can answer myself— Castaspella told him, placing a hand on his shoulder. —I understand why you're asking, of course. I'll be happy to answer all your questions. But I suppose I should begin by mentioning my brother is entirely unrelated to this.

—Naturally. I didn't mean to imply anything. I'm merely curious because no one expected the Tyrant to be… willing to share her authority.

—Well, you're right. She's far from willing, but… came to find it necessary— the sorceress began. —You see, when I was invited to join the council, I was barely twenty. I didn't expect to be respected at all, neither me as a person, nor my ideas. However, I still spoke my mind and shared my views, plans, and strategies, and they happened to be good enough that the Tyrant gave me a chance— she explained. —With time, I proved useful, and while hard to control, Shadow Weaver admitted she needed my help and that it'd be unwise to lose me as an asset.

—Asset?

—It's hardly a surprise that she sees people around her as assets, is it not?

—Clearly. Which means you must be… quite outstanding.

—Thank you, Your Majesty— Castaspella giggled. —I think I'm more stubborn than anything else, but- Well, I should accept the praise this time— she admitted, blushing

slightly.

—You should, yes— the Queen nodded. —Regardless of the reasons behind it, it's clear you have earned the Tyrant's trust. So, you'll be glad to know, I'm more than willing to discuss the cooperation agreement with you— she finally decided.

Chapter End Notes

So! Before I forget, Frosta's mom calls her a "baby" because she's her mother lol but actually, Frosta is already 5 here!
Also, regarding Frosta, I had to make so much math to figure out the age omgs… Anyways… Supposedly, Frosta's birth wasn't like a super public thing? And there's like a moment later when Angella and Casta talk about Frosta… OG that scene was when Casta FIRST learnt about her, but then shit happened and the notes went out of the window lol

SO ANYWAYS!! We must adapt XD

Etto, nvm, see you in a couple of days with ch 10!!! ~~I don't remember rn what it was about hahan't~~

Thanks for reading!!! ^_^

Chapter 10

Chapter Summary

> "Silence! You're a disgrace! That was such a poor performance! You should have died with your crew!" ~ SW

Chapter Notes

> Time for my "AO3 Author™" moment: I got my fingers burnt with caramel two days ago! And I wrote/edited this chapter yesterday with one of them in gauze! :D So, ehen't…
>
> Ok, so, this chapter is… Oof
>
> There are *updates* regarding the Council! That's the main focus of this chapter :D
>
> I'd rather not say anything else >v<
>
> Please enjoy!

See the end of the chapter for more notes



A few months passed after Castaspella successfully managed to reach an agreement with the Queen of Snows, and there was, fortunately, no need for her to leave again.

After all, the few days she spent at the Kingdom of Snows were a true torture in Mystacor.

Or, well, it could have been far worse.

People seemed to have been holding their breaths for all three days, the council had absolutely no idea what to do, and Shadow Weaver preferred to spend her time locked up in her room, keeping watch over Castaspella.

Well, that was the past now.

There were no incidents, and that's what mattered to them the most.

However, and as a result of the agreement, little by little more and more new sorcerers joined Mystacor, all of them hailing from the Kingdom of Snows.

Training programs had to be adjusted, as well as food relocation, and of course, extra effort was put to keep the people of Snows far from danger… and from Shadow Weaver.

However, the reality of war soon returned to remind them that danger lurks everywhere.

As the Horde launched a particularly strong attack on Bright Moon during the late afternoon, Shadow Weaver decided to send Ekaterina and her team to support Micah's army and defend the kingdom.

Hardly an hour or so had passed when Castaspella caught a distress signal.

It was Ekaterina.

The young Queen appeared on the Whispering Woods, having teleported with some effort to an area she knew well, and was only lucky to be safe from the still on-going attacks of the Horde.

Ekaterina's signal had come from an area close by, but the spell to send it isn't that precise so it would take Castaspella some time to find the councilwoman and her team.

She could hear Shadow Weaver's voice in her head telling her she should have used the Pulse spell before leaving Mystacor…

But it was unnecessary.

Keeping herself hidden with a cloaking spell, the sorceress navigated the area until she found bodies.

Many bodies.

Soldiers of the Horde, Bright Moon guards, and sorcerers…

One moved their hand just enough to call her attention, and Castaspella rushed to check who it was.

—Ekaterina? Oh, Stars…— she sighed, realizing it was her.

—Casta? What…

—I got your distress signal.

—We must leave— she uttered, breathless.

—Where's your team?

—All dead— she whined, trying to stand up and feeling an acute pain on her back.

—What!?— Castaspella gasped. She was too late. —I'm taking you back.

The young sorceress knew she was not good at teleportation spells yet, but she had no other choice. She made her best effort, and quickly got Ekaterina back to Mystacor.

—What exactly happened!?— Shadow Weaver's voice roared, finding them as soon as they appeared at the entrance of the main building.

—Ma-Master…

—Silence! You're a disgrace! That was such a poor performance! You should have died with your crew!

—Beatrix! Shut up!— Castaspella immediately barked back, squinting at the Tyrant.

—She's right…

—No, she's not!— she reacted, looking back at Ekaterina, still holding her. —You did what you could! You survived, and now need to be healed! Not chastised!— she defended her. As a pair of acolytes had approached to see what was happening, Castaspella called them over. —Please take her to Councilwoman Anya and make sure she gets treatment for her wounds. Careful with her back…

—Yes, Your Majesty— they both said in unison, before slowly taking Ekaterina away.

Castaspella remained kneeling on the ground, silently watching the acolytes disappear with the councilwoman, and eventually let out a deep sigh she didn't notice she was holding.

—That was unnecessary. You were too hard on Ekaterina. She did *not* need you lecturing her right now.

—I only stated a fact. Her performance was poor, so much so that her team died. She should be ashamed…— the Tyrant was saying, until she heard her sobbing. —Are you crying?

—Don't you understand!? Those were our people! Acolytes of Mystacor! Giving their lives to fight off the Horde! And you just- You- How can you be so *cold*!? Why can't you care a bit more, about the lives that were lost, about the courage it took to be there, fighting head on with a technologically-advanced army, and without anyone defending them!?

Castaspella could hardly speak anymore between the sobs; her throat closed as she felt a lump forming due to the anxiety and the pain.

And Shadow Weaver? Well, she felt awkward now. She had no idea what to do, how to console her partner.

Should she kneel with her and say something? But what?

Should she apologize? No, she'd notice it's just an attempt to calm her down and not a heartfelt apology. After all, she doesn't regret what she said…

And asking Castaspella what she needed now would hardly be useful, probably would further upset her.

So she stood there, frozen, until the Queen brushed away her tears, stood up, and with reddened eyes gave her a sorrowful look Shadow Weaver couldn't bare.

—I can't apologize.

—And you shouldn't. I know you wouldn't mean it— Castaspella replied, voice still broken. —So just… give me some time. I'll be in my room.

—You can take my room, I'll stay away.

—No need— she insisted, before walking away.

Later that night, Ekaterina was finally awake and recovered enough to walk out of her room. She went to have dinner alone, and then her fellow councillors found her on her way back to her chambers.

—Rina?— Daryon called.

—Uh? Oh, hi— she uttered, surprised to see all of them behind her, yet with hardly any strength to speak.

—Can we talk?— Kenno asked, noticeably worried.

—O-only if you feel alright— Anya clarified. —Take it easy for now.

—Can it be later? I'm… not fine.

—Of course. We'll be where you know— Daryon nodded. —Probably until midnight.

—Alright. I'll find you in a few hours if I can— she told them, trying to smile through the pain.

—Just don't push yourself. We can always talk tomorrow— Ayax insisted.

The councilwoman finally rested on her bed after washing her face.

She had been crying again.

Not because of the pain, but because of the heartache.

She felt… betrayed.

Or, maybe, the right word would be *disillusioned*.

Why being free from her infatuation hurt so much?

Maybe because of the way her illusions and hopes were shattered.

And now, she couldn't sleep.

She tried for an hour, but kept staring at the ceiling.

Eventually, she looked at the time; it wasn't midnight yet, so she supposed her fellow councillors would still be *there*, and decided to attend the gathering.

Maybe talking about it would help her.

She always disliked showing weakness, probably due to Shadow Weaver's aversion, or maybe because she thought a warrior sorceress like her had to be tough at all times. But now… perhaps it was time to be open about her destroyed heart.

—I don't know. I just- I guess I saw it in her eyes— Kenno admitted. They were all sitting around a table, some with drinks, some with a small snack. —I hope she will talk to us.

—Like I said, she seems to be struggling emotionally— Anya reminded them. —So, I think you're right. But, you know her…

—She's always putting up that strong heartless façade, but I also know she's still vulnerable and… I don't want to say soft, but, more sensitive than she seems— Daryon sighed.

—However, we shouldn't pressure her— Ayax pointed out. —She will come to us if she needs, and only speak if we give her the space. If she feels comfortable enough. Otherwise, she'll clam up— they explained.

—Yes, of course.

Silence settled for a moment, and they considered maybe it was time to end the gathering, yet the door opened before any of them could suggest it.

It was Ekaterina.

—Hi— she shyly let out. —Am I still in time?

—Of course, Rina— Daryon nodded, with a sad smile.

—I-I couldn't sleep— she admitted, approaching slowly.

—Come, sit down— Anya exhorted her, adding a chair to the table.

—Do you want something? Food, drink?— Kenno offered.

—No, thanks— she denied. Letting out a deep sigh, she admitted —I know you're worried about me, and I appreciate it. So… I wanted to talk.

—You don't have to if you're not ready— Daryon reminded her.

—It's better if I do it now.

—Then go ahead— Ayax invited her.

Ekaterina took a deep breath and exhaled, closing her eyes for a moment.

—Do you- Did you have any questions?

The four exchanged a glance, silently deciding who would ask, and finally Daryon took the lead.

—We do. We noticed something, after your return, and… we heard from Castaspella that Shadow Weaver was particularly harsh about… what happened.

—Yes— she sighed, looking away. —It was- I felt so…— she tried to explain, yet began sobbing. —She said I should have died with them!— she finally managed to say, covering her face as her tears fell. —Do we really mean so little to her!?

Anya didn't hesitate to offer her a hug, and was surprised when she accepted it.

Meanwhile, the others looked away, ashamed.

They had always pushed the thought aside, even when it was explicitly stated, and yet…

As they all kept silent while she cried, Ekaterina finally forced herself to stop and sit straight again.

—I'm sorry, Rina— Daryon uttered, not daring to look at her.

—No, *I* am sorry for what I'm going to say— she replied, sniffing. —I know how you all feel for her, so I hope you won't be mad at me, but I… no longer feel like that. I'm sorry.

—Don't be sorry— Ayax denied. —We would never police how you feel.

—I'll still obey and all, but… I have no love left for her in me— she clarified. —From now on, my loyalty lies with Castaspella alone.

—We understand— Kenno nodded. —And you still have our support, of course.

—Thank you— she sobbed, covering her face again.

Chapter End Notes

Welp, there u have it!
Poor Ekaterina TT-TT

But hey! At least Mystacor is now, little by little, opening up to the world!!

<("^_^) Anyways…

That was all for this week, see you next Monday!
~~And wish me luck finishing the last two chapters (>A<)~~

Chapter 11

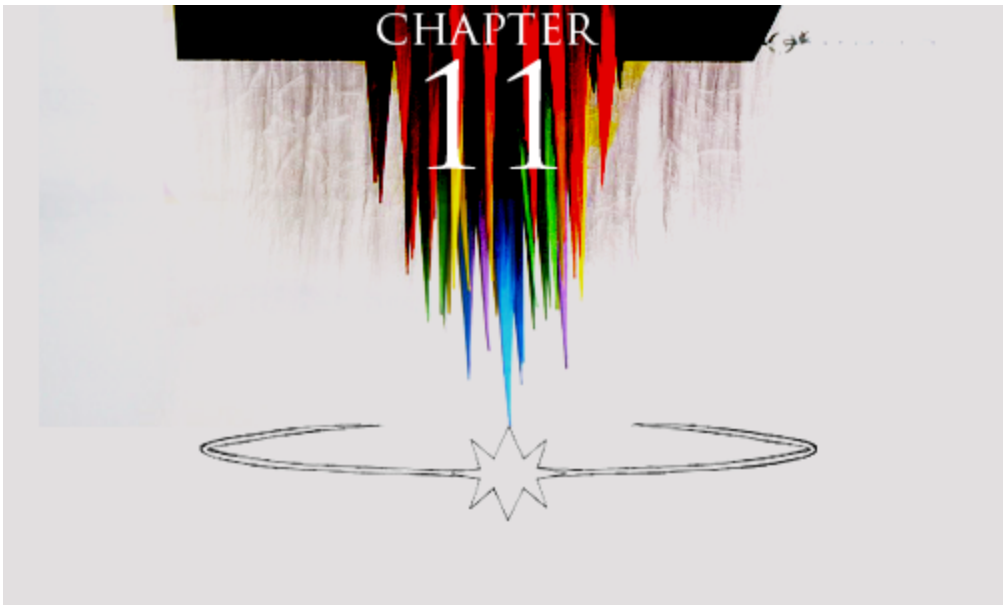
Chapter Summary

> "About ten years ago, Hordak had left the Fright Zone and I thought it'd be… a good moment to attack. However, he was back sooner than expected… *with a baby*" ~ SW

Chapter Notes

> Ooooooohhh welcome back!! I have an interesting chapter today!! ~~But not better than the next one~~
>
> AHEM, let's not spoil the fun…
>
> Please, enjoy! :D

See the end of the chapter for more notes



Another birthday passed for Castaspella, and hitting twenty-six felt like a dream.

She still felt so… *young*.

But in a bad way.

On an island where everyone in charge was older than her, she couldn't help feeling immature…

It surprised her that anyone at all listened to her, but perhaps her position was the reason- No, no. She *knew* she had earned it. She needed to start trusting herself a bit more.

Oh, but it was still so strange thinking about how time had passed. Glimmer would be eleven soon!

Glimmer would be eleven soon…

She'd be old enough to study at Mystacor in less than two years!

Well, she definitely had work to do if she wanted things to be good enough by then…

At least they were having a good start with the new acolytes from the Kingdom of Snows!

Feeling fairly optimistic, Castaspella attended the programmed council meeting.

Yet, curiously enough, Shadow Weaver wasn't there.

They waited for the Tyrant for a while before the woman stormed in, angry beyond compare, slamming the doors.

Not good at all.

—Everyone out— Castaspella ordered, standing up. —Now!

She was serious; all the councillors immediately complied and closed the door behind them, leaving the women alone.

—You *do not* give orders here!

—I do since you made me *Queen*!— the young sorceress reminded her. —Besides, you *know* I'm just protecting them!

—Are you?— she defiantly retorted, looking at the door.

—I am— Castaspella insisted, immediately casting a protection spell on the door. —Now your magic is confined here.

—You will regret this.

—No, I will not— she firmly replied. —Do whatever you want, attack me, yell at me, I'm not going anywhere until you calm down!

—Why won't you *stop* defying me!?— Shadow Weaver barked, sending dark magic her way.

Yet Castaspella didn't even flinch.

Instead, she only rolled her eyes as the wave of magic bounced off her.

—You need someone to defy you once in a while, remember? Otherwise, you get stuck in mediocrity— she pointed out, smirking.

—Your cockiness will doom you one day— the Tyrant insisted, seething.

—Oh, really? And who will make that happen? *You*!?— Castaspella laughed. —Give me a break…

—Don't you give *me* orders now!— she yelled, once again trying to attack her with black magic.

However, while the young sorceress *was* protected, she realized it was unnecessary. Shadow Weaver was surrounding her in darkness, but not really trying to hurt her.

—How long will you keep this up? Why don't you just tell me what's wrong?

—It's none of your business!— she seethed.

—It is if you're acting like this! Just speak!

—No!

—Bea, please!

—Shut up!

—I won't!

—Then *leave*!

—Not happening either! Talk to me!

With a low growl, Shadow Weaver approached her suddenly and stopped barely a breath away from her face.

Towering over her, she angrily told her —Did you know the Horde takes children into the Fright Zone!? Did you know they have been doing it for *years*!? Did you know, no one, not even *us*, has done anything about it!?

—What!?

—I saw two new kids being taken today! A brunette girl with locks and a small blond boy— she explained, looking away and closing her hands in fists. —I've been seeing it for so long! All those kids! They have probably been raised as soldiers! And do you think any of the princesses ever cared!?

—Wait, wait. Calm down. Why are you suddenly enraged about this!?

—Because… About ten years ago, Hordak had left the Fright Zone and I thought it'd be… a good moment to attack— she began, still towering over her, seething. —However, he was back sooner than expected… *with a baby*.

—What?— Castaspella gasped.

—I told myself that he must have quickly disposed of them, but now I think… that baby was raised as a soldier too. Maybe already died— she concluded. —And we've done *nothing*.

—Why have you never brought it up?

—I did back then, years before you joined— she scoffed. —Do you think anyone paid me any attention? Do you think anyone cared?— she spat, disgusted.

—So you have been pretending nothing happened, or that nothing could be done about those kids?

—Exactly— she admitted, clenching her jaw, yet little by little calming down. —But now… I'm clearly getting soft, and it's *your fault*.

—Hey! Don't you blame that strange *maternal* instinct on me!

—What instinct? I'd suck as a mother.

—Oh, I know. That's why I say it's strange. You care, in a twisted way you do, but you'd never show it, and you *certainly* wouldn't be able to raise someone properly.

—Very funny— the old sorceress snarled.

At least she was calmer now, and they could talk.

—Now, seriously: we know that there are kids in the Horde, and we know they are probably being trained to be soldiers. So what are we going to do about it?

—What do you expect? Nothing! We can't do *anything*!

—What about just… being more careful with how we take out soldiers? Undermining the Horde without hurting them?— Castaspella proposed.

—No, no. That's not enough. I-I need to get them *out* of the Horde— she let out, pacing in front of her. —Leaving them there was a mistake.

—Listen to me: you can't just storm in and take a bunch of kids with you…

—Why not!?— she reacted, stopping her pacing to look back at her.

—You don't have a plan!

—What plan could possibly be enough!?

—Hey, look. Just- Why don't we try to come up with a small mission to rescue at least some of the kids? We… we can't save them all. We don't even know how many there are… So let's start small— Castaspella suggested.

—You would… help me?

—Of course!

—You're more insane than I thought— Shadow Weaver mocked her.

—I have to match your insanity somehow— the Queen replied, smirking.

Meanwhile, outside, the councillors could hardly stop Ekaterina from returning inside.

—It's been too long! What if she did something to Casta!?

—Calm down! You know she'd never hurt her!— Daryon reminded her.

—No, I don't know!

—Yes, you do!— Anya replied, worried. —We've already seen it many times!

—No, no! This is different!

—Rina, please— Daryon pleaded. —Just give them a bit more time. You'll make things worse if you go in there!

—I'll regret it if I let that *monster* hurt her.

—Listen— Ayax began. —If anyone can survive Shadow Weaver's rage, that's Casta. Trust her.

—I… I trust her! But…

—Please, don't worry. She'll be fine— Kenno assured her, placing a hand on her shoulder. —Come on, let's go.

—No, I want to wait here, at least.

—I'll wait with her, you go— Daryon sighed.

As the rest of the councillors walked away, Ekaterina gave him an ashamed look and muttered —Thanks… And, uh, sorry. I didn't mean to call her a monster.

—Oh, you absolutely did. But we don't mind.

—Shut up… Of course you mind.

—Rina, she hurt you. We understand.

—Stop *understanding*— Ekaterina snarled. —You don't have to pity me. You still love her, and can act like it. Just…

—No one is pitying you. We're sorry that…

—That what!?

—That you had to be hurt like that.

—I didn't have to! It was my own fault!

—Rina…

—Shut up, Daryon. It's alright. And you didn't need to stay with me.

—I wanted to— he smiled.

With a deep sigh, the councilwoman closed her eyes and calmed down at last.

—Alright…— she let out. —Five more minutes.

—Of course.

By the time Castaspella finally left the council room, Ekaterina was about to leave.

—Oh! You both are still here?

—Rina was a bit worried…

—What happened!?

—Nothing too serious- Well, it *is* serious, but nothing to worry about.

—Casta— Daryon sighed. —She was- We noticed the protection spell on the door.

—Yeah, she was a bit angry, but I swear…

—Casta…

—Alright! Yeah! If it wasn't for those spells, things would have gone differently. But she just needed a little push to tell me what was wrong, and we've worked out a plan to fix it.

—And what was wrong?— Daryon further asked.

—Apparently, the Horde has been kidnapping kids and raising them as soldiers. So…

—What!?— both councillors gasped.

—I know, I reacted the same way.

—Wait, you don't mean you will…

—We are devising a mission to rescue some of them— Castaspella nodded, interrupting Ekaterina.

—That sounds insane— she scoffed. —You'd risk your life for that!?

—I'll try to do some good…

—How do you *know* it's good!?— the councilwoman insisted.

—It's better than to leave them to be raised as soldiers that then *we* will kill!

—Are you sure about this?

—I am— Castaspella nodded, resolved. —Trust me.

—We trust you.

Chapter End Notes

So!?
Did you guess it!?
If you didn't, it's ok, no worries
I'll tell you: THE KIDS ARE COMING SOON!! >v<

Fortunately, next chapter is in just a few days, hehe :D

Thank you for reading!!

Chapter 12

Chapter Summary

Were they going to infiltrate the Horde with nothing but their magic? Yes.

Would they grab the first kids they could and make a run for it? That was the plan.

Did that mean literally kidnapping? Absolutely.

Chapter Notes

Woke up early to post this, oops...
Ahem, so!

Ooooh it's finally here!!!

The chapter where THE HORDE KIDS COME INTO SCENE!!

Heck yesssss!

Ahem, anyways… Please enjoy!! :D

See the end of the chapter for more notes



A few months passed, it was a new year for Etheria, and the leaders of Mystacor kept working on their plan to "do something about the kids in the Horde".

And that something was getting further and further from ethical, moral, or *safe*.

Shadow Weaver didn't care in the slightest about any of that, of course, but Castaspella…

Well, at this point, Castaspella was only helping her to make sure the woman wouldn't get herself killed or worse.

The Tyrant never cared about the means, only the end; since no one would help her, why would she care about ethics? No, no. She'd play with the Horde's rules… or lack thereof.

Meanwhile, the young Queen *did care* but she cared even more about Shadow Weaver's safety, and if she wanted her to return, then she'd have to tag along.

Were they going to infiltrate the Horde with nothing but their magic? Yes.

Would they grab the first kids they could and make a run for it? That was the plan.

Did that mean literally kidnapping? Absolutely.

One night, they finally did it.

As they ran out of the Fright Zone and into the Whispering Woods, unable to teleport while carrying two unconscious children, they didn't notice three small figures following them.

—Hey, careful— Castaspella warned Shadow Weaver, noticing her squeezing the cat-like girl she was carrying a bit too hard. —Like this, gentle— she whispered, showing her how she held the light-haired kid she had grabbed.

Grabbed.

She didn't want to think too much about it, but yeah, at least she needed to make sure that the poor children wouldn't wake up in pain.

Yet they both remained oblivious to the three figures *still* behind them…

Eventually, they reached the cliff from where they could enter Mystacor by foot; they were almost there.

However, Castaspella hesitated before jumping into the mist…

—What are you waiting for?— Shadow Weaver hissed.

—No-nothing… Just…

—Hey!— a tiny voice suddenly exclaimed behind them. —I want my friends *back*!— the same voice added, accompanied by the click of a weapon.

The sorceresses turned around slowly, but never let go of the unconscious kids.

—It's a girl— Castaspella noticed, surprised when she saw the blue-eyed blonde girl who had spoken.

—I can see that— the Tyrant scoffed. —Quite the spirit you have, kid— she mocked her.

—Shu-shut up! Let go of my friends!— she insisted, trying and failing not to tremble.

Behind her, a brunette girl and a lizard-boy were shaking just as much yet still tried to hold their blaster-guns pointed at them.

—Alright, calm down— Castaspella said, revealing the blond boy in her arms was unharmed. —See? He's just asleep.

—And now it's your turn— Shadow Weaver smirked, before waving her hand and putting the three to sleep too.

—Hey!— Castaspella complained. —How are we carrying them all now!?

—Magic— the Tyrant simply replied.

—You said…

—It's a short distance now. We won't wear out for carrying them levitating to the room.

—Fine…— the Queen groaned, rolling her eyes.

Five kids.

They went for two and ended up with five children who grew at the Horde!

And now they had one chance to convince them to stay…

—*Convince*!?

—We're not retaining them here if they don't want to stay!— Castaspella pointed out.

—So everything we did was for *nothing*!?

—You think they will *want* to return to the Horde!?

—It's all they know. It's not impossible.

—Alright. Then let's give them a reason to stay!

—*How*!?

—First, calm down. Yelling will certainly do *wonders* to make them want to *return*— the young Queen mocked her. —Second: think. What do you know about the Horde? What could they want to have that they didn't there, or what could they hate that they *won't* have here?

—Proper food, to begin with. Well, I actually don't think they would "want" proper food since they don't know that's even a thing…

—Another thing. Think about something else. What have you seen?

—Well, they have complained about having to train so often, getting no rest… Some of them dislike their uniforms…

—Do they have proper baths at the Horde? Or do you think offering them the possibility of using hot water may convince them?— Castaspella asked, pensive.

—Maybe.

—Alright, that's it. I'll go talk to them.

—Just with that?

—I mean, there must be more, but we won't know until we *talk to them*!

—Sure— Shadow Weaver sighed, rolling her eyes. —Do as you prefer. I'll go back to work.

—Yes, do. I don't think you should meet them just yet.

Meanwhile, the kids abducted from the Horde were waking up in a windowless room, almost empty save for the bunk beds in which they laid. It was… not that different from their room at the Horde, actually, just more… colourful.

—Ah!— Adora gasped, as soon as she realized she was *not* smelling rust. —Where's- Catra?— she asked, noticing her sprawled on the bed next to hers. —Wait! Kyle!?— she then exclaimed, as she recalled her second kidnapped friend, and scrambled to get up to check the beds above her. —You're all here!?

—Adora… stop yelling…— Lonnie mumbled, half asleep.

—What… time is… it?— Catra asked, yawning. —Wait- Where- I'm… alive?— she then realized, patting her body and checking her tail. —Did I have a nightmare?

—Nope— Adora somberly denied. —Look around us.

—This isn't the Horde.

—What do you mean?— Lonnie asked, annoyed, but finally opening her eyes. —What!? Whe-where are we!? Why's this… this bed so… comfortable?

—I don't get it. Wasn't I kidnapped with Kyle? Why are you guys… here? And *where* is "here"!?

—We went after you both, Catra— Adora explained. —We followed those women, and… and… I don't remember anything else— she admitted, scratching the back of her head.

—Then we should get back. Now— the young magicat sentenced. —Wake them up, Lonnie, we're going back to the Horde, one way or another.

—We don't know where we are?

—And!?— Catra asked back, annoyed. —It's somewhere we *don't know*! What if it's worse than the Horde!?

—Ca-Catra is right. We don't know anything other than the Horde— Adora supported her. —Let's try to go back.

—Ugh…— Lonnie grumbled. —Fine.

While she woke up the boys, Adora felt around her body too, looking for her blaster-gun.

Of course she didn't have it.

But she did have some odd… piece of wood or something. It felt warm. And, for some reason, Adora decided to keep it in her pocket where she found it.

Once all five kids were awake and ready, Catra pushed the door open enough to take a peek.

The hall, just as colourful as the room, was empty, so she gestured at them to silently step outside.

The five tiptoed close to the walls and away from the windows, carefully peeking through doors and trying not to make a sound.

And then they reached what they could only describe as a common area… full of kids their age and below.

It was an inner garden, but that's something the Horde didn't have, obviously…

Right that moment, there was a loud gasp as the mystacorean kids noticed the Horde kids, and Catra immediately leapt back, hairs standing on end and hissing loudly. Adora got in front of her, and between Lonnie and Rogelio, they covered Kyle.

There was no door and, behind them, only wide windows with no glass.

—Who are you!?— the older kids questioned them.

—How did you get here!?

—They are from the *Horde*!

And immediately, younger kids began yelling —Horde scum! Horde scum!

Fun.

Adora could almost feel Catra itching to attack them, and she could hardly blame her… but…

—Wait— she told them, while the annoying kids kept insulting them. —Don't attack.

—And let *them* attack us!?— Catra scoffed.

—Agreed— Lonnie growled.

—We can defend ourselves. But don't attack first. Don't… don't give them a reason— Adora insisted.

If they had been kidnapped by Princesses, as she thought, then they couldn't act like them.

They had to think.

Maybe those kids were victims of the manipulations of the princesses!

They couldn't hurt innocent people! Much less kids like them!

But then the first projectile was thrown.

A kid threw a shoe at them, and Adora braced for impact.

But it didn't… hurt.

Why?

Adora looked back to the kids, only to be shocked by the sight of the angry faces, throwing more shoes at them, yet the second and the third, every single one bounced back without so much as a gentle tap against them.

For some reason, her hand went to the wooden piece she found on her pocket, and somehow… she knew it.

—What's going on!?— Lonnie exclaimed, terrified.

—We'll be fine— Adora assured her, trying to calm her down.

—Oh, we will! Because I'm getting us out of here!— Catra barked, about to launch herself forward. —Don't! Let me!— she yelled, struggling against Adora's grasp. —Why can they attack us, but I can't!?— she then questioned her friend, tearing up.

But Adora didn't answer. She only hugged Catra, who froze in place.

A thousand thoughts raced through her mind, none stick, all just rushed past, and only when she heard the familiar commanding tone of a superior, did her mind stop.

She didn't know that voice, but she could recognize the tone of a leader when she heard it.

Catra was finally released as Adora looked at the same person she was staring at.

—She's the one who took Kyle!— Lonnie recognized.

—But she's… telling *them* off— Catra uttered. —Why?

—…I do *not* want to see anyone behaving like this again, am I clear!?— Castaspella was ordering at the thirty-something pairs of pleading eyes. —Now, everyone, back to your rooms, and you will *not* come out until lunch!— she ordered. —I want all of you to reflect and think about how you treat strangers!

—Bu-but they-they have the Horde symbol!— a kid argued.

—And *that* gives you the right to throw your shoes at them!?— the sorceress scoffed, hands on her hips. —No, no. I will not tolerate this behaviour!

—What's happening here?— another voice suddenly asked, walking into the garden from the opposite side.

—Why was there no supervision here!?— Castaspella asked back.

—I *just* learnt the kids were out here on their break, and…

—Who let them out of the dining room?— she insisted, albeit calm.

—I-I don't know.

—Ah… It doesn't matter— she sighed. —I don't want unsupervised kids here, or *anywhere* anymore. Am I clear?

—Absolutely, your Majesty— the acolyte nodded, ushering the kids out of the garden and back to their rooms.

Silence at last.

Castaspella took a deep breath before facing the Horde kids; what a terrible first- no, second impression.

—Well, good morning, kids— she began, smiling gently but staying at a distance.

As expected, Adora immediately extended her arms protecting Catra behind her.

—Don't come closer! You took my friends!

—I know, I know— Castaspella admitted, apologetic. —I promise I didn't mean to harm them in any way. I- We just wanted to bring them here where they would be safe.

—Safe!? From what?— Lonnie scoffed.

—We were safe from the Princesses at the Horde!— Adora argued.

—Well, but… were you or weren't you training to go to war?

—It's our duty— she insisted, much to the sorceress's dismay.

—You are *kids*. You should be playing and learning, not… *training for war*.

—No, no. We *have* to return— Adora assured. —We-we…

—Alright, I understand— Castaspella interrupted, noticing her fearful expression. —Let's make a deal then. Stay here for the day. If by nightfall you *still* want to return, I'll *personally* take you all back.

—You… mean it?— Catra asked, suspicious.

—I swear— the Queen nodded.

The five kids exchanged silent glances, but they all eventually waited for Adora to decide.

—Alright. Deal— the little blonde girl accepted, putting a serious face that made her look a bit older.

—Fantastic— Castaspella smiled. —Why don't we get you some breakfast now? You must be hungry…

As if on cue, Rogelio's stomach grumbled, soon followed by Kyle and Catra's.

—A-alright— Adora nodded, face red with embarrassment as her stomach betrayed her too.

—Then, come with me. I'll take you to the dining room. You'll have it all for yourselves— she told them, gesturing at the kids to follow her out of the garden.

Soon, the five were sitting at a large table, curiously looking at the dishes that were set in front of them, but making no move to eat.

They seemed… suspicious.

—Why are these… so colourful?— Catra asked, squinting at her plate.

—And why do they have so… so many shapes?— Lonnie seconded her.

—Do-do you have gray ration bars?— Kyle innocently asked.

—Uh…— Castaspella hesitated. —Kyle, was it?— she asked, and he nodded. —Alright. Kyle, I have no idea what you are talking about.

He seemed about to try to explain himself, when the door to the dining room opened and Shadow Weaver walked in.

As soon as Catra saw her, she let out a yelp, hairs standing on end again.

Adora's first instinct was to cover her again, just like Rogelio covered Kyle with his arms… But then the Tyrant laughed.

—What's wrong?— she asked, her tone mocking.

For some reason, hearing her speak in such a manner made Adora say —A-are you from the Fright Zone?

What now?

—You're right, she looks like it…— Lonnie agreed.

—Do you know why the food's so strange?— the blonde girl further asked, before Shadow Weaver could reply the first question.

—You think I'm from the Fright Zone?— she finally asked back, hardly holding back her amusement. —No, kid. I am not from there, hadn't set foot inside your little headquarters until yesterday, so I am not familiar with what you are used to eating.

—They called them "ration bars"— Castaspella told them.

—Oh, I *did* hear that term before— she nodded. —This is real food.

—Real?— Kyle uttered.

—I promise you, it's safe to eat— the young Queen insisted. —And I'm sure you'll like it.

—O-okay— Adora stammered. She then looked back at her friends and, while placing a hand on Catra's, who was still unnerved, she suggested —Let's all try it together.

—Fine…— Lonnie accepted, a bit grumpy but more hungry than anything.

That way, the five kids attempted to eat… with their hands.

—Stop— Shadow Weaver ordered. —Do you *not* know how to use a fork?— she scoffed. Their faces were loud enough: they didn't even know what that was… —Ugh, what do they teach you in the Horde!?— she complained, finally approaching the table. She went behind them and, starting with Adora, showed her not-so-gently how to hold the fork, grab a portion of food, and told her —Now get it into your mouth.

A bit scared, the blonde girl did as ordered and almost dropped the fork.

Eyes open wide, she happily chew the food.

—Me! Me! Now me!— the other four kids began pleading.

Well, Rogelio was actually growling, but Shadow Weaver inferred he was also asking to be taught.

The Tyrant looked up at Castaspella, confused beyond compare, and the Queen only gestured at her to go ahead and guide them all one by one.

While Adora cheerfully told them how *good* this weird food tasted, the old sorceress repeated the process of teaching them to eat properly, first with Catra, then Lonnie, Rogelio, and finally Kyle.

—There. Now you all know. I don't want to see you eating with your hands ever again— Shadow Weaver sentenced, before turning around to leave. —I guess I've seen enough— she uttered as she passed by Castaspella, who decided to follow her.

—You keep acting all tough and uninterested, but that right there is what I mean when I speak about your maternal instinct— the young Queen teased her, getting immediately cornered against a wall. Squinting defiantly, she further pushed the matter, saying —Will you try to deny it?

—I *told you* not to mention that in public— the Tyrant reminded her, removing her mask just to tease Castaspella by lingering only a palm away from her face. As usual, she began playfully threatening her —Since you broke that rule, whatever should I do to teach you a lesson?

—In my defense, we *are* completely alone here…

—Hmm… You're off the hook, for now— Shadow Weaver accepted, before kissing her.

After a moment, as they parted, Castaspella noticed the door to the dining room was ajar, and the five kids were there. Watching.

Oh, oh.

The Tyrant noticed pretty quickly too and immediately turned away from them to put her mask back in place.

But it was too late now.

—What happened to her face?— Catra asked.

—Oh, Dear, it was just an accident— Castaspella began.

—You should *not* be spying like that— Shadow Weaver scoffed, still looking away and standing behind the young Queen.

—Stop that. You literally spend half your day spying on people— she reproached her.

—It-it looks painful— Adora then stammered. —Does it hurt?

Castaspella felt her heart ache as she saw the worry in their faces.

These kids, whom they had *kidnapped* no less, seemed so concerned about her…

—It was, but… that happened a long time ago, she's fine now— she decided to reply, since Shadow Weaver remained quiet. —Did-did you finish your food?— she then asked, not bearing the silence. The five nodded and she nodded too. —Great. Then let me show you the island, alright?

Chapter End Notes

Well, that was it for this week!! I can't believe it's already ch 12, damn…

Good thing I finally made progress with Ch 14 and should have it finished soon. That will give me a bit more time for Ch15, damn…

Apologies if the writing gets bad the last two chapters
I got stuck, wasn't expecting that, and well… I am doing what I can to at least finish TT-TT

See you next week!! :D

Chapter 13

Chapter Summary

> Maybe she did have a little bit of a cyclical problem when it came to Castaspella.

Chapter Notes

> Man… yesterday was such a *day* over here in my country…
>
> Anyways, here's the new chapter, the following one should be ready to move here, and… I need to finally write the last one, omgs (/^\)
>
> Wish me luck, and happy reading!!

See the end of the chapter for more notes



At the end of the day, the kids agreed to stay in Mystacor.

Castaspella's approach had been the right one, it seemed.

Shadow Weaver was… confused.

Part of her was glad, part of her was irritated; she felt both relieved and indignant.

Why was the young sorceress always right!? Why did it seem like she was better at *everything*!? Way did everyone like her *more*!?

And why did the Tyrant suddenly care about whether people liked her or not!?

Oh, she was losing it…

Maybe she did have a little bit of a cyclical problem when it came to Castaspella.

Ugh!

She did *not* want to think about it.

Not now, not ever!

It could also be related to the presence of kids so close to them now.

Castaspella was *not* good with children, but Shadow Weaver definitely couldn't be left unsupervised around them.

So, for the most part, the Tyrant was always irritable since the young Queen's constant chastising made her feel… well, like a child herself.

It was far from ideal. Shadow Weaver had two different sources of annoyance driving her crazy, and she strangely cared for *both*!

On the one hand, the kids demonstrated within weeks just how clueless and under-taught they were. Clearly they hadn't been educated at the Horde in *any* way that mattered! And even where they had, like gun-handling, they were pathetic!

That was the first source of annoyance.

On the other hand, and as a consequence of the kids annoying her, there was Castaspella constantly cutting her short when she spoke- *yelled* at the children for being so useless.

—You don't understand! I tell them off because I want them to *learn*!

—That's not the way!— Castaspella immediately scoffed. —I'm glad that you care about them, but you are *not* showing it *properly*!

—Listen: those kids are *pathetic*. They don't know how to do the most basic things! And whoever taught them how to use those blasters messed up fantastically! They don't even know how to maintain the guns! They could have blown on their faces! They are *lucky* we took them away from there before it ever happened!

—Okay, okay. So they weren't taught much, and what they *were* taught, was not good enough — Castaspella nodded. —That means you can probably do it better, but yelling and belittling them is *not* how you'll manage it!

—I am angry! It's driving me crazy!

—You need to be patient! You lash out at the smallest of things!

—And you are *very* quick to catch that, aren't you? You keep telling me off like I'm the one in the wrong, and…

—Because you are! Even if your correction is accurate, the manner is *not*!

—Just admit you enjoy the feeling of superiority!— Shadow Weaver seethed.

—No, I don't— Castaspella uttered, voice low. Looking away and rubbing her arm to soothe herself, she explained —I actually don't like telling you off constantly. I do… I-I liked bantering with you, defying you, like it's out little game… But- I mean, this is different and I wish it wasn't necessary.

—If you don't like doing that, then *do not do it*!

—No. I will *not* leave those kids at your rage's mercy! And I am absolutely not leaving you alone in this. Do you think I don't notice how much you struggle?

—I don't struggle.

—You do. You-you are trying to do what's best for them and you feel like they are undermining themselves. Don't you?

—Yes…— the Tyrant admitted.

—Then let's just…

—Keep doing it.

—Huh?

—Chastise me when I lash out, put a stop to my rage. But do me a favour and explain to me *why*.

—Of course, gladly— Castaspella smiled, glad that she changed her mind. She then leant forward and kissed her briefly before exhorting her —Let's go to bed.

As expected, of course, it kept happening.

Three months passed since the kids decided to stay, and even with the little issue of keeping them safe from the Tyrant's wrath, the improvement was noticeable.

Plenty of times, Shadow Weaver would lash out for a moment until the young Queen swiftly caught her, just in time before anyone could be hurt. But every time, once Castaspella laid it out for her, the old woman understood and, reluctantly, calmed down.

In fact, the Queen had put a simple rule: whenever she'd go angry, she had to find something positive to focus on instead.

Anything, no matter how small.

And this time, she had to nudge the Tyrant a bit, but in the end she gave up.

—Yes, yes… I guess they are… fast learners— Shadow Weaver admitted, albeit seemingly suffering for it.

—They are! I think they'll soon be ready for proper shooting classes— she nodded, beaming.

—Right…

—Why are you so skeptic?

—I'm not *skeptic*, you are too…

—"Too" what!?

—Too *naïve*! Why do you trust them so much?

—Oh, come on! You *just* admitted they are fast learners…

—For *certain* things, yes— Shadow Weaver scoffed, folding her arms. —But they won't listen half the time. If they start shooting before they've perfected their technique, they might hurt themselves.

—You cannot be serious- How are they going to perfect it if they don't *start shooting*!?

—If they don't follow orders either…

—Come on… Bea, please— Castaspella sighed.

—The day that kid starts wearing shoes, maybe I…

—Who?— the Queen briskly asked, totally guessing who she meant but annoyed that Shadow Weaver wouldn't call her by her name.

—The cat-girl…

—Catra! Say it: Ca… tra…

—Why…

—Speak properly about those kids, or I'm not continuing this conversation— Castaspella cut her.

—Ah…— the Tyrant sighed. Pressing her temples, she started again —*Catra*, who refuses to wear boots even after I taught them all to do as much, is an example of how those kids cannot be trusted to follow orders.

—You do realize there's a difference between "following any order blindly" and "following life-saving orders", right?

—I see no difference.

—That's a shame because there's a big one— Castaspella insisted. —For example: There's a reasonable explanation for why life-saving orders must be followed, while there are many unreasonable orders that have absolutely no grounds to be imposed!

—They *must* wear boots. It's only proper. I don't want to see them barefoot again— Shadow Weaver retorted.

—No, no. It's *conventional*; you know what else is conventional? Showing your face in public. But…

—I'm uncomfortable doing so.

—Perfect! And Catra is uncomfortable with footwear!

The Tyrant was taken aback for a moment.

What… Why… Ugh!

Fine! She was right!

—She could get hurt…

—Her feet are *made* to be barefoot. Yes, she could get hurt, just like any of us could get our hands hurt, but you don't see everyone wearing gloves, do you?— Castaspella pointed out.

—Ugh…

—Listen, Bea. Please…

—*What*!?

—Can you please calm down and stop being so hard on those kids?

—I can't make promises…

—You never can— the young Queen sighed.

—That's unfair.

—No, no. I mean…— Castaspella tried to explain, but interrupted herself with another deep sigh. —I don't want you to make empty promises, but I wish you would, at least once, try to make an effort to promise something and fulfill it.

—Casta…

—It's alright. You don't need to do so now— she gently smiled, cupping her face. —Just think about it.

Eventually, the Tyrant gave in and the classes finally began… about four months since their arrival.

They started alright, but… maybe Shadow Weaver wasn't patient enough to see that.

For her, they weren't ready yet and the classes were a mistake.

Castaspella hoped to prove her otherwise, but perhaps… that would be more difficult than expected.

It was maybe the fourth class that day, and no matter how hard she tried, Lonnie couldn't shot straight at all.

—Enough!— the Tyrant finally yelled. —It is *clear* to me you're shooting so poorly you'll sooner hit your team than the target!— she scoffed, towering over her. But then, black magic began oozing from Shadow Weaver as she seethed —You're a disgrace! A menace to your teammates! You'll never be ready like this!

Without hesitation, Castaspella surrounded Lonnie with a shield and firmly ordered —Step *back*.

Squinting at her, Shadow Weaver complied, but immediately tried to complain —I don't…

—You go back to your room, Sweetheart— Castaspella told Lonnie, ignoring the Tyrant for a moment, until the girl had left. Turning back to look at her, she severely said —Breathe, control yourself. Focus.

—She could have *killed* someone.

—I understand, but she *wasn't* pointing at anyone— the young Queen insisted.

—Can I continue the class? Or is this your way of ending it?

—Of course, you can continue. If you promise to keep yourself *calm*.

—Fine…— she sighed. —I'll try— she then muttered, looking quite grumpy. With a deep breath, she straightened her back, and told the remaining kids —Alright, we don't have all day. Keep shooting, and don't take your eyes *off* the target.

Castaspella was surprised with how well Shadow Weaver managed to keep calm after that. In fact, she even remained controlled as she corrected Catra's hold on the blaster.

But then…

—Why don't we learn magic like the other kids?— the little magicat asked.

—Because you have no magical potential for sorcery— the woman simply replied. —Your abilities lie… elsewhere…— she concluded, notoriously careful with her choice of words.

Castaspella was actually quite proud of how hard she was trying.

But that didn't last long…

Shadow Weaver's words reminded Adora —But you said I had magical power in me.

And she *did* say that just a few months before…

—I said you have *something* magical in you but it cannot be shaped into sorcery…

—You're lying!— Catra scoffed, suddenly angry, throwing her blaster-gun to the ground.

Shadow Weaver simply watched the girl run away, and sighed as Adora immediately followed.

Castaspella had no time to react at all…

Fortunately, maybe strangely enough, the Tyrant didn't explode but rather focused on the two remaining kids and patiently explained Rogelio how to grab the blaster without his fingers interfering with the trigger.

However, as the lizard-folk focused on her instructions, Kyle was too impatient to wait for his turn and struggled with his gun on his own… pointing at Rogelio.

—Stop!— Shadow Weaver barked, as soon as she looked back at him. —You're *too close* and if the blaster is jammed, then you must be extra careful and point *to the ground*. And *away* from your feet, if it isn't obvious…— she added, rolling her eyes.

Kyle sighed and apologized weakly, but for once Shadow Weaver didn't care.

She was so tired… These kids were *draining*.

Castaspella silently observed as the Tyrant let Rogelio practice a few last shots, and checked Kyle's jammed blaster-gun.

—Is-is that a rock!?— he exclaimed, intently watching as the old woman used magic to get the small pebble out of the gun. —How did that end there!?

—If you don't know…

—No idea— he admitted, defeated.

—Alright, that's it— she sighed. —I want you both to clean your weapons and leave.

—Clean?— Kyle asked, as if translating Rogelio's growl.

—You… don't know how to clean your- What have you been doing every time I asked you to clean them!?— the woman indignantly asked, in utter disbelief.

—We, uh… checked if they had any filth?

—You're… serious— Shadow Weaver realized, taking a deep breath.

—Alright, alright. You can still learn— Castaspella pointed out, stepping closer. —Right?

—Sure… The next class, I'll teach you *all*, so don't miss it. Now leave them here and I'll clean them myself— the Tyrant ordered.

Immediately, Rogelio and Kyle obeyed and left.

As the women were left alone, Shadow Weaver groaned…

—I know… That was…

—Terrible. Not only their shooting, *everything* was terrible!

—Don't be like that— Castaspella tried to encourage her. —Next class you'll teach them, and they'll keep practicing, and…

—And then maybe, *just maybe*, one day they'll be competent!

—Bea…— the young Queen sighed.

—No, save it… I don't… I can't right now.

—I know, I wasn't going to say anything— Castaspella assured her, placing a hand on her shoulder as the old woman sat to clean the blasters.

—Better.

—Let's do something: teach *me* how to clean these, and then I'll tell you if there's anything to improve in how you explain— the sorceress proposed, smiling brightly.

—Fine…

Chapter End Notes

Alright, that was it…
I woke up very early to post this, and today I have my last chance to get the disability certificate to secure my meds <("^_^)
So once again, wish me luck and, in whatever case, I'll see you on Thursday :D

Thanks for reading!!

Chapter 14

Chapter Summary

> "You don't have to be the monster you've made yourself to be all this time. Let me help you" ~ Castaspella

Chapter Notes

> Oh goddess..... I seriously hope I manage to write next chapter in time-
>
> AHEM, anyways!!
>
> Welcome to Ch14!!! We're ALMOST done!!! ~~I almost forgot the banner img lol~~
>
> Etto, let's see, uh… Nothing, just… Horde-kids shenanigans today :D
>
> Please enjoy!!

See the end of the chapter for more notes



A couple of months after the "incident", Shadow Weaver considered she had to leave the class in someone else's charge.

—After this last test, you'll be assigned a tutor to supervise your training from now on, and I'll only return for the exams…

—Wait, what!?— Lonnie scoffed.

—You promised to teach us!— Kyle pointed out, seconded by Rogelio's roar.

—We've done *everything* you asked for, and now you wanna ditch us!?— Catra complained.

—Guys…— Adora tried to calm them down, but they all began talking at the same time.

—Enough! You have a test to take— Shadow Weaver interrupted.

—Not until you promise to keep teaching us!— Catra retorted, defiant.

Soon, all five kids were echoing the demand, and the Tyrant gave Castaspella the most suffering look ever.

In reply, the young Queen gestured encouragingly, and Shadow Weaver let out a long sigh.

—Aright, bunch of rascals. Let's make a deal— she proposed, hands joined behind her back. —If you all, *all five of you*, pass this test and properly dismantle, clean, and reassemble your blaster-guns, I'll stay in charge of your classes.

—Deal!— Adora exclaimed, excited.

More encouraged now, the five kids took their places and diligently disassembled, cleaned, and reassembled the blasters.

This test wasn't timed, of course, but there seemed to be a bit of a competition going on between Catra and Adora, and of course, Catra finished just a second before Adora, making her loudly celebrate.

After another moment, the other three had finished too, and while Shadow Weaver had been observing them, she still went one by one picking up the blasters and checking every detail.

—Alright. Now shoot— she ordered. —One by one, in the order you finished.

That meant Catra went first.

Flawless shot.

She turned around to look at Shadow Weaver, excited, waiting for a compliment, or at least and acknowledgement, but she was already ordering Adora to shoot next.

Then Lonnie, Rogelio, and finally Kyle.

None of the kids got a comment, so Catra didn't feel that bad.

It still bugged her, but it wasn't personal.

Right?

—Can I ask something?— Kyle then spoke up, raising a hand.

—Sure…

—Do we- I mean, why should we clean the blasters?

—First answer this: How did it feel to shoot just now?

—Comfortable! A-and smooth!

—Exactly— she smirked. —In general, if you regularly maintain your blasters, they will shoot better. However, it is important to keep them properly cleaned so they don't explode between your hands, harming them or your faces.

—Huh? Wait, is that what happened to your face?

—Kyle!— Lonnie told him off.

That… shook Shadow Weaver for a moment.

But it was evident in their expressions that they all had the same question now.

She didn't want to answer, at all, yet it would probably be worse to let them think whatever they wanted, maybe even develop a fear of their blaster-guns, which would be extremely counterproductive.

As she locked eyes with Castaspella, searching for an answer, the Tyrant took a deep breath and sighed.

Alright, she would do this.

—No. It was an accident with magic. As I've told you before, you cannot be taught sorcery, not only because you lack the potential, but also because it's far more dangerous than these poor blasters of yours— she began, scoffing with pride. —No… You cannot meddle with magic for the same reason you must keep these clean: you won't like what happens if you fuck up.

—Yikes— Lonnie uttered.

—Yes, that's an appropriate reaction— the old woman laughed. —Now, I suppose… you all passed…— she sighed. —Fine, I'll keep teaching you.

As the five kids celebrated loudly, Castaspella failed to hide her smile, and Shadow Weaver didn't hesitate to call her a fool for it.

—Alright, alright— the young Queen then said. —I think we can end the class here, right?

—Ah, yes, lunch— Shadow Weaver sighed. —You take them to the dining room. I have a few more things to check.

—Sure— Castaspella accepted.

The kids were quite eager.

Shadow Weaver knew that well.

They were… they were hungry for practice.

They wanted to learn new skills every day, Shadow Weaver kept having to stop them from jumping to new lessons until they had at least mastered what they had just learnt…

It was no surprise that they became something like her personal apprentices.

Shadow Weaver hadn't had such dedicated pupils since…

Never mind.

This was not the same, clearly.

The thing was, the old woman still remained the Tyrant of Mystacor, which meant they weren't exactly treated nicely.

Somehow, they weren't scared away by this, maybe they were too stubborn, as she considered, or maybe they were used to this, as Castaspella proposed, since they came from the Horde.

Only that comparison to the Horde kept Shadow Weaver from unleashing her full rage on them, but she was still quite… mean.

Castaspella had to tell her off plenty of times.

It was far from fun for everyone.

—What!? What great piece of insight will you regale me with today!?

—If you really care for their safety…— the young Queen began one day. —Why have you become their greatest threat!?

—I am not…

—Yes, you are!

—You know what!? I don't care. If that's the case, poor them, they should leave me in peace.

—Bea!

—Don't…

—We're alone…— Castaspella pointed out, waving her hands around.

—We're still outside and could get eavesdroppers any time— the Tyrant pointed out, eying the gardens around her as if expecting to spot someone spying.

—Fine. Beatrix! What is your problem today!?

—You don't even want me to start listing them all…

—Oh, come on! You're just being a baby at this point!

—I am!?

—Yes!

—How exactly!?

—Don't you see what you do!? You-you're so violent to them! And you justify it!

—Give me one example— the Tyrant defied her.

—Yesterday before lunch.

—They were being disobedient.

—Beatrix!

—You know I cannot let those things pass or they will keep doing it!

—How- What do you call "disobedience"!? Literally, Catra and Lonnie were complaining about being hungry!

—I've explained several times that food is limited!

—Then just tell them so!

—I did! And they started yelling!

—I'd much rather you walked away and leave them screaming than envelop them in darkness to "shut them up"!— Castaspella argued. —I'm not even asking you to calmly explain why they can't eat more than their portion- I literally offered to do that! Why couldn't you just call me!?

—I didn't?

—No! If Adora hadn't fetched me, I wouldn't have arrived in time to stop that madness!— the young Queen scoffed. —And this is barely the most recent example!

—I am trying to keep them…

—Don't say "safe"! You just want them to obey you at any cost. You're seeking nothing but self-benefit here.

—What!?

—Listen: You just want them to obey you. Nothing else— Castaspella began. —You *think* that by obeying you they will be safe as a *result*, but that is not necessarily true!

Shadow Weaver glared back at her with barely contained rage.

Fine!

She was… maybe right.

—What exactly do you propose, then?

—If you don't have the patience to explain things, call me. If you fell like punishing someone, walk away. If you feel like blowing something up, go to the training area and blow up a dummy! But do not punish these kids— she went on. —Actually, don't punish anyone! Blow off some steam in some other way. Just… I don't know, go punch a tree. I don't care.

—You speak a lot for someone who does *not* understand what I go through— the Tyrant scoffed.

—Oh, really? Alright, then go ahead and *tell me*.

—I don't know *how*!

—Beatrix, listen… I'm not saying it's easy, but can't you at least *try* what I suggest you before refusing!?

—No. I will *not* do any of those things. I cannot be *seen* walking away or just blowing up a tree!

—But…

—Now, you listen to me, Casta: I have been doing this for long enough time. I *think* I can keep doing what I know…

—But, in all this time, when was the last time you had children as pupils?

—Are children really that different from adults!? Don't answer that— she interrupted herself, raising a hand. —Fine, yes, I suppose they are more… volatile.

—They… are kids. They are impressionable, they will be marked for life if you…

—Save it— Shadow Weaver spat, turning around. As she stepped closer to a flowerbed and crouched in front of it, she sighed —I don't- I *understand* what you mean, but I *don't* like it.

—I know— the young Queen admitted, looking down. After a moment of hesitation, she joined the old woman next to the flowers. —I'm glad you're at least trying.

—*Trying*— she scoffed. —It's pathetic.

—You're harsher with yourself than with anyone else, sometimes— Castaspella pointed out. —Which is ironic since, other times, you literally try to pass your every action as nothing below perfect— she then laughed.

—Now who's being mean?

—Hurts! Doesn't it!?— the sorceress further mocked her.

—Where are you trying to get?

—Nowhere. I'm mocking you.

—Bitch!— Shadow Weaver exclaimed, bumping against her shoulder to make her fall. —Not on my flowers!— she then yelped, catching Castaspella and pushing her onto the empty ground.

—You- Mean!— she complained, catching her wrist and pulling her along. As the Tyrant fell on top of the young Queen, Castaspella's expression softened. —You don't have to be the monster you've made yourself to be all this time— she gently said. —Let me help you.

—I don't think I have a choice anymore— Shadow Weaver sighed, leaning down to kiss her.

Chapter End Notes

Alright, it's late, this chapter had just one or two rounds of editing, I'm also a bit unwell, so I don't really have much to say, but I *so so* hope you enjoyed today's chapter :)

I'll do my best to have the last one written in time, specially since it's my WIPBB claimed posting day, but uh… I don't know if I'll manage…
I promise I'll try!!!

See you next week if I succeed!! :D Thank you for reading!!! (#^_^#)

Chapter 15

Chapter Summary

> "None of those kids, including Adora, trust the princesses, alright? But they trust *us*. So what about we discuss this with Angella, maybe the rest of the Alliance too, and figure out what we can do for Adora?" ~ Castaspella

Chapter Notes

> The last chapter at last, omgs!!
>
> I managed to finish it in time, I'm shocked! TT-TT
>
> Anyways, I hope you enjoy it, and see you at the end notes!!

See the end of the chapter for more notes



Castaspella woke up that morning feeling a bit dizzy, yet still noticed, almost immediately, that Shadow Weaver hadn't slept.

—What has you… so restless this morning?— she asked, yawning in the middle.

—Who says I'm restless?

—I do…— the young Queen insisted, wrapping her arms around the old woman. —Don't try to deny it… I'm not stupid— she insisted, yawning again.

—Sure, sure. Whatever. I just couldn't sleep— the Tyrant replied.

—Why?

—I was… thinking… about stuff.

—If you won't tell me what it is, then I have to guess it's about Adora's powers once again…

—How did you…

—I know you, Bea— Castaspella interrupted, smirking a bit. —You're obsessed with that.

—I am not…

—You literally lose sleep thinking about it- What part of the past few months doesn't look like obsession to you?

—I just wonder whether her power needs shaping, that's all…

—Except that you *want* to shape it, regardless of whether it needs to or not…— Castaspella pointed out, tapping her fingers on Shadow Weaver's chest.

—Even so, I can't; I am sure her powers are more like those of the princesses, nothing *I* have access to.

—But you have knowledge— the young Queen considered. —None of those kids, including Adora, trust the princesses, alright? But they trust *us*. So what about we discuss this with Angella, maybe the rest of the Alliance too, and figure out what we can do for Adora?

—But…

—Look: Next year, Glimmer will be joining us to start her training in sorcery; I think we can take advantage of the occasion, and discuss both matters with Angella!

—You seriously- Ah… fine— the Tyrant sighed, giving up. Laying her head back on the pillow, she took a deep breath and sighed again. —Guess we have a day ahead of us.

—We do. So let's get some breakfast already— Castaspella smiled, pushing herself up.

It was around lunch-time when Angella and Micah visited Mystacor, bringing Glimmer along.

Castaspella had promised them, many years ago, that the place would be better, good enough for the young princess of Bright Moon to study without issues, without risk… But they wanted to see it for themselves.

After a short tour around, Shadow Weaver offered to leave them with the young Queen to further discuss matters.

—Are you sure?— Angella asked, confused.

—Absolutely.

—Then yes, please, leave us— Micah nodded.

—You have until lunch is ready— the Tyrant smirked, walking out of the small inner garden where they had concluded the tour.

—Rude…— Angella scoffed.

—Oh, worry not— Castaspella quickly dismissed her. —I haven't even ordered lunch yet— she giggled.

—Wait, so… Why did she say that?— Glimmer asked, confused.

—She's just being mean…

—Auntie…

—Yes, Sweetheart?

—I really like it here, but… she won't be my tutor, right?— the teen asked, side-eying her parents.

—If you don't want to, no— Castaspella confirmed. —You saw all the acolytes from the Kingdom of Snows: they all were explicitly asked, and they all refused to have any classes dictated by Shadow Weaver. And then there's the five kids brought from the Horde… They are the opposite: they explicitly *requested* Shadow Weaver to teach them.

—Why would they want that!?— Micah asked, disbelieving.

—Horde kids? How did they arrive here?— Glimmer asked instead.

—That doesn't matter…— Angella immediately said, giving Castaspella a stern look.

—Absolutely, don't worry about it— the young Queen quickly agreed, knowing full well Glimmer would eventually find out. —And to answer your question, Brother, they were promised personal tutoring by her, and they decided it had to be fulfilled…

—What!?

—You don't want to know the details, trust me— she chuckled.

—Wait- I can *choose* who will teach me!?

—Well, uh, not exactly… You can choose whether Shadow Weaver can be involved in your training or not…

—Then why could they choose her to be their tutor!?— Glimmer insisted.

—Because she has enough knowledge to teach anything. Other tutors don't, so, for everyone else, the tutors they have will depend on what subject they are trained on…

—And what if I want *you* to teach me!?

—Oh, Glimmer…— Castaspella uttered, covering her mouth. —I'd love to, but I can only train you on defense magic… For everything else, you'd need other tutors.

—Fine! Then have the Tyrant teach me!

—Huh!?— her parents exclaimed, confused.

—You mentioned earlier that you supervise her classes…

—But it's only supervision, which is necessary because Shadow Weaver is… a complicated person. Dangerous to leave alone around… people.

Angella had to stifle a laugh but then nodded solemnly when Glimmer looked back at her.

—Alright, but you keep her in check, so I'll take it— the princess insisted.

How stubborn…

—You will not get training from Shadow Weaver— Micah firmly sentenced.

—I will! I decide so!— Glimmer rebuked, folding her arms.

For a twelve-year-old kid, she was pretty feisty.

—Okay! Alright! As you wish— Castaspella accepted, much to her brother's indignation. —But you better get along with the kids from the Horde…

—Yeah, yeah, sure. How hard can it be?

The young Queen finally ordered for lunch to be prepared and invited her brother and his family to stay.

During the meal, Castaspella purposely distracted Glimmer and Micah to give Shadow Weaver a chance to explain what she felt in Adora, and ask the Queen of Bright Moon how it could be trained.

Shaped.

She kept her ears open in case anything interesting was said, yet it ended in nothing.

All Angella could say was that they should talk to the Queen of Snows, the only person who still knows about things everyone else has forgotten.

Hence, after they three left, Castaspella immediately discussed the matter with the Tyrant.

—Why would she send us to speak with someone else!?

—If you can guess her motives, I'll reward you— Shadow Weaver replied, smirking.

—Bitch!— the young Queen complained. However, the old woman only folded her arms and kept silent. —Fine! Let's see… I think she knows something. Maybe just doesn't know she knows and doesn't want to make the effort- No, wait, that's a bit odd… Uh, maybe Angella knows the Queen of Snows can give us useful information, but maybe- Ugh, this is frustrating.

—Continue that line of thought: Why wouldn't Angella say it herself?

—Be-because… Well, uh, maybe she doesn't want to…

—Why wouldn't she want to?

—Be-because…

—*Think*.

—Oh! You mean because that would make her responsible!?

—Indeed— Shadow Weaver smirked. —Any information she gives us regarding Adora's dormant power can make her the one to blame for what we do with that information.

—That's ridiculous, Bea…

—Not for the Alliance, no.

—Then why would the Queen of Snows give us the information Angella won't!?

—I don't know…— the Tyrant sighed, turning to leave. —Of course, we can be wrong about that and maybe she genuinely doesn't know, nor does the Queen of Snows…

—What!?

—Regardless: Write a letter to the Queen, will you?

—Why me?— Castaspella immediately asked, confused as she followed Shadow Weaver down the hall.

—Because I'm delegating that to you…

—You're being lazy again!

—Me!? *Never*…

—I hate it when you do that— the young Queen scoffed.

—Listen: diplomacy is your thing. Simple as that.

—Alright! Sure…— she finally accepted, muttering angrily between her teeth.

Unfortunately, the Queen of Snows had no idea how anyone who wasn't from royal lineage could have dormant magic similar to that of the princesses and the runestones…

However, the woman had the most vast collection of information about these matters, even greater than the archive of Mystacor, and she promised to find them an answer.

A promise that seemed further and further away from fulfilling with each passing month.

In the meantime, a new year began in Mystacor.

As arranged, Glimmer took defense classes from her aunt, and everything else was taught by Shadow Weaver… who was less than thrilled with the new addition.

Other than sorcery, the young princess' classes for every subject were shared with the kids that came from the Horde. The Tyrant did *not* tolerate the petty discussions that kept sparking between them, but that certainly didn't stop Catra and Glimmer from arguing every class.

—Cause you're too slow…

—What!? I'm not *slow*!— the princess scoffed, fists coming to life with pink light.

—You *a-are*!— Catra mocked her. —What you gonna do about it, Sparkles?

—Guys, guys! Calm down…— Adora tried to intercede, getting between them.

—Oh, no. Let me *show her* what I can do!— Glimmer growled.

—No! You aren't supposed to use magic- Catra!— Adora exclaimed, noticing her friend had taken out her blaster-gun.

—What? It's only fair…

—Stop! Both of you!— she finally yelled, surprised to hear her words echoed. But it made sense when she turned to find Castaspella standing tall at the entrance. —Finally…— she sighed.

—Enough with this— the sorceress firmly ordered. —Where is Shadow Weaver?

—We don't know— Catra admitted. —It's just us three.

—Then where are Lonnie, Rogelio, and Kyle!?

—We didn't see them at breakfast either— Adora admitted.

—And you called *me* slow!?— Glimmer complained.

—I said *enough*!— Castaspella reminded her. —Alright. Come with me. We'll look for them.

—Oh! Will you use the Pulse spell!?— her niece asked, excited as they approached a basin filled to the brim with water.

—No. *You will*— the young Queen replied.

—What!?

—Come on, try— she encouraged her.

As the princess looked back at Adora and Catra, getting a thumbs-up from the first and an eye-roll from the second, she swallowed hard and took a step closer to the basin.

—Who-who do I look for?

—Who can you see clearer in your mind?

—Probably the Tyrant…

—I imagine— Castaspella sighed, taking it as a bad sign. —Alright, go ahead.

Under her aunt's careful watch, the princess steeled her nerves and cast the Pulse spell, conjuring images of the Tyrant, who happened to be with the three missing kids.

—Where's that?— Catra asked.

—They… are in the- That's the training grounds. Why are they there?— Adora noticed.

—I'm more concerned about them being alone with her. What even happened!? You didn't have training today other than theoretical!

—Well, they seem fine, don't they?— Glimmer asked, genuinely surprised.

—That's *more* suspicious, Sparkles— Catra scoffed. —Hold up!— she then exclaimed, alarmed. —There's someone else there.

—Is there?— Castaspella inquired, looking closer. —Oh… I see— she sighed, serious. —Come with me, girls…

Soon enough, the young Queen was walking into the training grounds, followed by her niece, Adora, and Catra.

—Morning…— Shadow Weaver casually let out.

—Morning— she replied aloud, before stopping next to her to mutter —Why didn't you tell me…

—I'm as surprised as you— the Tyrant whispered back. —*Handle it*.

—Oh, I will— she replied. Then, straightening her back, Castaspella looked at their guest and began —Excuse the late appearance, your Majesty.

—Nothing to apologize for— the Queen of Snows replied, looking away from the kids and back at her. —I *did* come unannounced. You found us pretty quickly, as a matter of fact.

—Just a simple spell my niece cast— she smiled, proud. —I see you're getting a bit of a demonstration…

—I've heard great things about these kids from my people, and as I happened to find them upon arrival, I requested as much, yes.

—I see…— Castaspella nodded, her sight on the three kids still shooting. —I normally supervise these trainings, but I'm sure it wasn't necessary this time…

—It *was*— Shadow Weaver scoffed. —Believe me.

—Fine. Enough idle chatter— the Queen of Snows finally said. —Kids, thank you for the demonstration— she told them, as if letting them know they could stop. —I have come today to speak with you, and with the girl called Adora— she revealed.

—Me!?

—Ah, good, it's you— the Queen smiled. —Would you like your friends to stay?

—I *am* staying, like it or not— Catra immediately said.

—Catra…— Shadow Weaver began, but trailed off as she felt Castaspella's hand on her shoulder.

—No, yeah! Let them stay. Wha-what is this about?— Adora asked.

—Have you been told you have certain dormant power within you?

—Yes— she solemnly nodded. Discreetly taking Catra's hand, she added —But it can't be shaped by sorcery, or… whatever that means. So it doesn't matter.

—That last part isn't true, my Child— the Queen of Snows denied. —I came to tell you what I've learnt in the past few months.

—Wait— Castaspella stopped her. —After… what? Six months, give or take, you finally found something about her powers and you… show up like this!? With all due respect, of course; I just find this a bit irregular.

—You're maybe too innocent to understand my reasons— she replied. —But I bet you are not — she then told Shadow Weaver.

—Of course— the Tyrant nodded. —You want to make sure the information reaches Adora in its entirety; if you just told us, I could have filtered and even twisted the information to my advantage.

—Shit…— Castaspella muttered. —I get it— she then nodded.

—Wait, you *would*!?— Catra indignantly exclaimed, seemingly seconded by Adora herself and even Glimmer. As the woman's mask kept a blank expression, she further complained —You *suck*, you know that!?

—I do— she snickered. —Now, tell us.

—Alright— the Queen of Snows decided to begin, joining her hands behind her back. —According to our records, an ancient magical weapon, a relic from the First Ones, was left in Etheria by an old hero…

—Huh!?— the kids collectively uttered, all of them at a loss.

Noticing as much, she further explained —The First Ones have been gone for centuries now, but they used to inhabit Etheria, Kids. And, of course, they left many signs of their life here… Buildings that are now ruins, texts no one can read, and some relics, like the one I just referred to.

—Alright, what about that relic?— Shadow Weaver asked, growing impatient.

—How insolent— the Queen scoffed. —*About it*, let me tell you, we know little. But one of the few things we know is that the weapon is connected to all the runestones in Etheria— she calmly explained. —Since you correctly assessed that Adora's power is similar to that of the Princesses, I've come to the conclusion that this specific relic may be the key to her power.

—Wait, so… I *could* use that power in me!?— she asked, eyes wide open.

—Exactly— the Queen smiled. —Supposing we find this magical weapon, there's a chance you can tap into it and unlock your potential.

—Wait, wait— Catra interrupted, pulling from Adora's hand. —That's just a *chance*. Don't get your hopes up— she first told her. Then, looking back at the Queen with suspicion, she asked —And who was that old hero, anyways?

—I doubt you've heard her name…

—Tell us!— she demanded.

—Alright: I'll tell you her whole story— the Queen agreed. —The story of the legendary She-Ra.

Chapter End Notes

And that was it for this part!!!!

Next year: **The Tyrant of Mystacor: Rise of A Hero** :D

I think you can guess who that is already XD

Ahem… Anyways, this concludes the fic for now, meaning my submission for the WIPBB 2025 is officially done!

I'm so happy TT^TT

Welp! See you in another fic, or next year :D BYE!

Thanks for reading!!

Works inspired by this one

Fic Cover & Chapter Headers For "The Tyrant of Mystacor: Rise of A Queen" by afteriwake

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